

Aristophanes  
KNIGHTS

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This text was first published in 2010 on the internet and by Richer Resources Publications  
(Arlington, Virginia, USA; ISBN 978-1935238744).

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TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Note that in the following translation, the line numbers without brackets refer to the English text and those within square brackets refer to the Greek text. In the former, a partial indented line is normally combined in the reckoning with the short line immediately before it. Stage directions and footnotes have been supplied by the translator.

In this translation, possessives of words ending in -s are usually indicated in the common way (that is, by adding -'s (e.g. *Zeus* and *Zeus's*). This convention adds a syllable to the spoken word (the sound -iz). Sometimes, for metrical reasons, this English text indicates such possession in an alternate manner, with a simple apostrophe. This form of the possessive does not add an extra syllable to the spoken name (e.g., *Demos* and *Demos'* are both two-syllable words; whereas, *Demos's* has three syllables).

The translator would like to acknowledge the valuable help provided by the notes in the editions of the play prepared by W. C. Green (1871), by W. W. Merry (1887), and by Alan Sommerstein (1981).

# KNIGHTS

## INTRODUCTORY NOTE

Aristophanes' *Knights* is a sharp, bawdy, and, in some places, grim satiric allegory on Athenian political life. While the targets of the satire are clear enough, the translator or editor is forced to make some decisions about the names of the characters, because specific names are given only to Demos (whose name means "the people") and to the chorus of Knights.

The main butt of the jokes is clearly Cleon, the popular demagogue of Athenian politics, but the character who represents him is called the Paphlagonian, and Cleon's name is mentioned only once in the play. The term *Paphlagonian* refers not to an origin in Asia Minor but to his very aggressive rhetoric, since the name comes from the verb meaning *to bluster*. The Paphlagonian's main opponent, the Sausage Seller, does have a name (Agoracritus, meaning "chosen by the marketplace"), but that fact does not emerge until very late in the play. Hence, I have used the terms Paphlagonian and Sausage Seller to indicate these characters (some other editions of the play use the names Cleon and Agoracritus throughout).

The two slaves who open the play are not named specifically in the manuscripts, but traditionally they have been called Demosthenes and Nicias, after the two Athenian generals who were enemies of Cleon. I have retained these names because that seemed better than making up alternatives or calling them Slave A and Slave B.

The term *Knights* refers to an elite group of about a thousand cavalry in the Athenian military forces. Each Knight had to provide his own horse and would have expenses he would have to pay himself. However, membership was considered socially prestigious and would be drawn from the richer, more aristocratic Athenians, who tended to be hostile to the populist demagogue Cleon.

At the time *Knights* was first produced (424 BC), Athens and Sparta had been at war for about seven years. The previous year Athens had won an important victory at Pylos against the Spartans, capturing a number of prisoners and bringing them back to Athens. Cleon engineered things so that he received the major credit for this success. As a result, he acquired considerable popularity and was awarded a number of state honours. However, in the view of many Athenians he had, in effect, stolen the credit from Demosthenes. This point is frequently mentioned in the play.

*Knights* was awarded first prize in the drama competition at the Lenaea festival in 424 BC.

## KNIGHTS

### DRAMATIS PERSONAE

DEMOSTHENES: a slave in the service of Demos.

NICIAS: a slave in the service of Demos.

SAUSAGE SELLER: a low-born Athenian street merchant.

PAPHLAGONIAN: a slave in the service of Demos.

DEMOS: an elderly Athenian citizen.

CHORUS OF KNIGHTS.

*[The action takes place in an Athenian street in the Pnyx, the part of the city where the public assemblies were held. At the back there is an entrance to the house belonging to Demos. From within the house comes the noise of a slave being beaten with a whip and crying out in pain.]*

DEMOSTHENES *[bursting through the door]*

All right, that's it, that's just too much to take!

I've had it! That bastard interloper!

That miserable Paphlagonian!

I wish the gods would obliterate him—

him and his schemes! Since that awful day

he came into this house, because of him

we slaves keep getting beaten all the time.

NICIAS *[coming out behind Demosthenes, in obvious pain]*

That man is the very worst—a first-class

Paphlagonian—all those lies he tells!

DEMOSTHENES

Hey, you poor man, how you doing?

NICIAS

Not good.

10

The same as you.

DEMOSTHENES

All right, come over here,

so we can moan together, pipe a tune,

a duet in the manner of Olympus.

*[Demosthenes and Nicias put their heads together and act as if they are both playing flutes, making whimpering sounds in harmony.]*

## KNIGHTS

DEMOSTHENES AND NICIAS

What can we do-o-ooooo, [10]  
We're just so black and blue-oo-oo.<sup>1</sup>

DEMOSTHENES

Why waste our time moaning? We should stop  
and look for some way to preserve our hides.

NICIAS

How could we do that?

DEMOSTHENES

Well, suggest something.

NICIAS

No, you tell me—that way I can avoid  
fighting you about it.

*[Here Demosthenes and Nicias briefly parody the grand tragic style.]*

DEMOSTHENES

No. By Apollo. No. 20  
I shall not speak.

NICIAS

Ah, if only you would tell me  
what I should say.

DEMOSTHENES

Come. Screw your courage up  
and speak. And then I shall confide in you.

NICIAS

But I dare not. How could I ever utter  
the delicate phrasings of Euripides—  
“Can’t thou not speak for me what I must say”?<sup>2</sup>

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<sup>1</sup>Olympus was a musician from the 7th century who composed flute music. The English words here have been provided by the translator; the Greek simply has them repeating a series of *mu* sounds, without any lyrics.

<sup>2</sup>Nicias is here quoting Euripides, a line from *Hippolytus* where Phaedra wishes to confess her passion for her stepson without actually saying the words.

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DEMOSTHENES

No, I don't want that. Don't toss those herbs around.  
Instead find us some way we can dance off [20]  
and leave our master.<sup>3</sup>

NICIAS [*miming masturbation*]

Then say, "Let's beat off"—  
all in one word, as I do.

DEMOSTHENES [*copying Nicias*]

All right, then, 30  
I say, "Let's beat off."

NICIAS

Now after "Let's beat off,"  
say "out of here."

DEMOSTHENES

"Out of here."

NICIAS

Very good.  
It's like when you give yourself a hand job—  
at first you say it gently, "Let's beat off,"  
then you quickly speed it up—"out of here."

DEMOSTHENES [*copying the gesture*]

Let's beat off . . . out of here, let's beat off . . .

[*Finally he sees what Nicias is getting at.*]

Ah, we beat off out of here—we run away!

NICIAS

Well, what about it? Doesn't that sound sweet?

DEMOSTHENES

Yes, by god, it does—except for one thing:

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<sup>3</sup>Aristophanes is satirizing Euripides's origins by reminding people of the false rumour that his mother, Cleito, sold vegetables. The previous lines also satirize Euripides's style.

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I'm terrified that beating it like this  
might be a prophecy about my skin.<sup>4</sup> 40

NICIAS  
Why's that?

DEMOSTHENES  
Because when you pound your snake  
the skin comes off.

NICIAS  
The way things are right now [30]  
the best thing we can do is head on out  
and throw ourselves down before some statue  
of a god.

DEMOSTHENES  
A statue? What kind of statue?  
Do you really believe that there are gods?

NICIAS  
Of course I do.

DEMOSTHENES  
What sort of evidence  
have you got for that?

NICIAS  
Well, I'm someone  
gods clearly do not like. Does that not count 50  
as confirmation?<sup>5</sup>

DEMOSTHENES  
Proof enough for me.  
So we'd better look someplace else for help.  
Do you want me to tell this audience  
what's going on?

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<sup>4</sup>The punishment for slaves who ran away during [wartime](#) was a ferocious whipping. Nonetheless, desertions were not uncommon.

<sup>5</sup>The fact that he is so wretched demonstrates that there must be gods. Otherwise he would be better off.

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NICIAS

That's not a bad idea.  
We could ask them to do one thing for us—  
show us by their faces if they enjoy  
what we say and do.

DEMOSTHENES

Then I'll speak up. [40]

*[He directs his explanation to the audience.]*

We have a bad tempered and crude master.  
He chews beans and is angry all the time—  
Demos of the Pnyx, a grumpy old man 60  
who's half deaf.<sup>6</sup> Last new moon he bought a slave,  
a Paphlagonian tanner, a great scoundrel,  
the most slanderous of rogues.<sup>7</sup> And this slave,  
this tanner from Paphlagonia, observed  
the old man's habits. He threw himself down  
at our master's feet and began fawning,  
wheedling, flattering, buttering him up  
with tiny scraps of leather, saying things like  
"O Demos, once you've tried a single case [50]  
then take a bath," "Taste this," "Gulp this down," 70  
"Eat up," "Take three obols," "Would you like me  
to get an evening meal brought in for you?"<sup>8</sup>  
Then that Paphlagonian grabs from one of us  
something we've prepared and offers it up  
to our master. Just a few days ago,  
when I'd kneaded a Spartan barley cake  
at Pylos, that devilish rogue somehow  
snuck past me, grabbed the cake I had just made,

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<sup>6</sup>The detail about chewing beans may be a reference to Demos's crude habits. Some commentators see an allusion here to the use of beans to count votes in the election of public officials.

<sup>7</sup>Paphlagonia is a remote, rugged area on the southern shores of the Black Sea. The reference to a "tanner" identifies the slave for the audience as Cleon, a powerful politician and general in Athens, whose family derived their wealth from a tanning business. He was not from Paphlagonia. That word, however, also alludes to a blustery style of speech. Cleon was an opponent of the richer, aristocratic classes and was very aggressive in prosecuting the war with Sparta.

<sup>8</sup>This is an invitation to Demos to cut short his public duties at the law court and enjoy the pleasures of a bath and food, while still taking the full fee for his services. Three obols was the daily amount given for jury duty (Cleon had had the amount increased from two obols). The phrase "tiny bits of leather" is alleging that Cleon distributes small bribes to get his way with Demos (the people).

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and presented it as his.<sup>9</sup> He makes sure  
we keep our distance and will not allow  
anyone else to attend on Demos. 80  
When our master's eating dinner, he stands  
holding a leather thong and flicks away [60]  
the orators. He chants out oracles,  
so the old man is mad for prophecies,  
and when he sees that he's quite lost his wits,  
he goes to work according to his plan—  
accusing those inside with outright lies,  
so we get whipped, while that Paphlagonian  
scampers among the slaves, making demands, 90  
stirring up trouble, taking bribes. He'll say,  
"You see how I set things up so Hylas  
got a beating. If you don't win me over,  
then you're dead meat today."<sup>10</sup> So we pay up.  
If we don't, the old man abuses us, [70]  
and we shit out eight times as much.

*[Demosthenes turns back to Nicias.]*

So now,  
my friend, let's come up with something fast—  
what path or person can we turn to now?

NICIAS

The best way, my friend, is that beating off—  
getting out of here.

DEMOSTHENES

But there's no damn way 100  
we can escape the Paphlagonian.  
That man sees everything. He has one leg  
in Pylos, and he keeps his other leg  
in the assembly—his two feet are spread  
this far apart.

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<sup>9</sup>In 425 BC (the year before the production of *Knights*) the Athenian general Demosthenes had engineered a military triumph against the Spartans at Pylos. Cleon had come out in the final stages of the campaign and together he and Demosthenes had inflicted a major defeat on the Spartans. Cleon received almost all the credit for the victory and, as a result, was extremely popular.

<sup>10</sup>Hylas is a common name for a slave.



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*[Demosthenes demonstrates his words by almost doing the splits and keeps talking from an awkward position, which gets worse as he goes on.]*

His arsehole is right here  
over the Chaones, his hands are there,  
in Aetolia, and his mind is over here,  
among the Clopidians.<sup>11</sup>

NICIAS

Then the best thing  
for us would be to die.

DEMOSTHENES *[straightening up]*

All right, let's see.  
The most manly way we two could perish—  
what would that be? 110 [80]

NICIAS

The most courageous way?  
The best would be for us to drink bull's blood—  
that's a good one to choose. Themistocles  
died from that.<sup>12</sup>

DEMOSTHENES

No, by god, not that. But wine—  
undiluted from the Good Spirit cup!  
Then perhaps we'll think of something useful.<sup>13</sup>

NICIAS

O yes, unmixed wine! It's natural you'd think  
of having a drink. But can anyone  
come up with good advice when **he** is drunk?

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<sup>11</sup>The Chaones are a group living in north-west Greece. The Greek names for these places bring out certain double meanings which are lost in translation (except perhaps for the pun *Cahones-cojones*). *Aetolia* sounds like the Greek word meaning *to demand*, and *Clopidae*, a small part of Athens, sounds as if it comes from the Greek word for *thief*. The basic satiric point is that Cleon's reach is extensive and corrupt everywhere.

<sup>12</sup>Themistocles was a leading Athenian politician at the time of the Persian invasions and played a decisive role in the Persian defeat in 480 BC. Bull's blood was believed to be poisonous. However, there is no reliable evidence that Themistocles died drinking it.

<sup>13</sup>After dinner a libation of unmixed wine was made to the Good Spirit (i.e., Dionysus). In the regular drinking which followed the libation, the wine was mixed with water.

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DEMOSTHENES

What a thing to ask! Bah! You're a fountain  
spouting streams of streaming bullshit! You dare  
complain that wine disturbs the way we think? [90]  
What can you find better than some wine  
for getting men to act effectively?  
You see that when men drink, they get wealthy,  
they are successful, they win their lawsuits,  
they become happy and help out their friends.  
Come, bring me out a jug of wine right now,  
so I can refresh my mind and think up  
something really clever.

NICIAS

By all the gods, 130  
what will you end up doing to both of us  
with this drinking of yours?

DEMOSTHENES

Something good.  
Go get it, while I sit myself down right here.

*[Nicias goes into the house.]*

For if I do get drunk, then I'll spatter  
tiny schemes and fancies, minuscule ideas, [100]  
in all directions.

*[Nicias returns from the house with large jug of wine and a silver cup.]*

NICIAS

It's a good thing  
I wasn't caught in there stealing this wine.

DEMOSTHENES

Tell me—what's the Paphlagonian doing?

NICIAS

That slanderous rogue has been licking up  
some cake he confiscated. Now he's drunk— 140  
lying on his back, snoring on his hides.

## KNIGHTS

DEMOSTHENES

Well, come on then, pour me a generous hit  
of that unmixed wine . . . for a libation.

NICIAS [*pouring out the wine*]

There. Take it and offer a libation  
to the Good Spirit.<sup>14</sup>

DEMOSTHENES [*smelling and then gulping down the wine*]

Drink this and swill down  
the fine Pramnian spirit. O excellent Spirit,  
the idea is yours—not mine.<sup>15</sup>

NICIAS

All right tell me.  
I'm asking you. What is that great idea?

DEMOSTHENES

Get inside there and steal the oracles  
belonging to the Paphlagonian—  
quickly while he's asleep.<sup>16</sup>

[110]

150

NICIAS

All right, I'll go.  
But I'm afraid I might find this Good Spirit  
becomes the genius of my misfortune.

[*Nicias goes back into the house.*]

DEMOSTHENES

Let's see now—I'll bring this jug over here  
beside me so I can moisten my mind  
and come up with some fabulous idea.

[*Demosthenes takes another drink. Nicias comes back from the house with a scroll.*]

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<sup>14</sup>A libation is an offering to a god in which a small amount of liquid (usually wine) is poured out onto the ground or an altar. Nicias suspects Demosthenes is simply going to drink the wine; hence, the latter reassures him that he wants the wine for a religious purpose. Ancient Greeks normally drank wine mixed with water.

<sup>15</sup>The term *Pramnian* refers to a wine of good quality produced in different places.

<sup>16</sup>The oracles are prophecies written out on scrolls.

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NICIAS

That Paphlagonian—what a noise he makes  
farting and snoring. Thanks to that I grabbed  
the sacred oracle, the one he guards  
so carefully, without him noticing.

160

DEMOSTHENES

You are the craftiest of men! Give it here,  
so I can look it over—and pour me  
a drink. Hurry up! Well now, let me see,  
what's in here.

*[Demosthenes reads the scroll.]*

O these prophecies! Quick!  
Give me a drink! Come on!

[120]

NICIAS *[pouring the wine]*

Here you go. Well?  
What does the oracle say?

DEMOSTHENES *[draining the cup and holding it out]*  
Pour me another.

NICIAS *[taking the cup]*

That's what it says there? "Pour another drink"?

DEMOSTHENES

O Bacis!<sup>17</sup>

NICIAS *[pouring out more wine]*  
What is it?

DEMOSTHENES

Quick! Pass me that cup!

NICIAS

Bacis really gets to use that cup a lot.

DEMOSTHENES *[looking at the scroll]*

O you disgraceful Paphlagonian!

170

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<sup>17</sup>Bacis was a well-known contemporary prophet, who is said to have predicted many events of the war. There is also a pun on Bacchus, the god of wine.

## KNIGHTS

So that's why you've been protecting yourself  
all this time! You're terrified of this oracle—  
it's about you!

NICIAS

Why's that?

DEMOSTHENES

In here it says  
how he's to be destroyed.

NICIAS

And how is that?

DEMOSTHENES

How? Well, this oracle clearly predicts  
that first a dealer in hemp will come along  
and, to start with, control city business.<sup>18</sup>

[130]

NICIAS

That's one wheeler dealer. So who comes next?  
Tell me.

DEMOSTHENES

After that one comes another—  
someone who deals in sheep.<sup>19</sup>

NICIAS

That's two dealers. 180  
What's supposed to happen to that second one?

DEMOSTHENES

He's to be in charge until someone else,  
a more repulsive man, comes on the scene.  
Once that happens, he dies. His successor  
is a leather dealer and a robber,

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<sup>18</sup>The dealer in hemp is Eucrates, an Athenian politician, who opposed and was removed from power by Cleon.

<sup>19</sup>The sheep dealer is a reference to Lysicles, who was killed in a military action in 428 BC. The repeated notion of political leaders who first make money from common trades, as Sommerstein suggests, is emphasizing a new breed of politician in the state, a middle-class merchant who uses his money to gain political influence and power.

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a Paphlagonian with a screaming voice,  
like the raging stream of Cycloborus.<sup>20</sup>

NICIAS

So Fate decreed that the dealer in sheep  
would be toppled by the leather dealer?

DEMOSTHENES

That's right.

NICIAS

Then heaven help us—we're in deep trouble!  
I wish some other dealer might show up  
from somewhere—just one!

190

[140]

DEMOSTHENES

Well, there is one—  
he has a splendid trade.

NICIAS

Tell me who that is.  
Come on, I'm asking you.

DEMOSTHENES

Want me to tell you?

NICIAS

Yes. For god's sake!

DEMOSTHENES *[reading from the scroll]*

The man who will destroy  
the Paphlagonian is a sausage dealer.

NICIAS

A sausage dealer? O Poseidon, what a trade!  
Where on earth do we find a man like that?

DEMOSTHENES

Let's go look for him.

*[Enter the Sausage Seller carrying a table, knives, sausages, and so on.]*

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<sup>20</sup>The Cycloborus was a stream near Athens which turned into a noisy torrent in the spring.

## KNIGHTS

NICIAS

Hey, there's one coming here,  
as if he's off to market. A stroke of luck!

200

DEMOSTHENES [*calling to the Sausage Seller*]

Hey, sausage seller—you blessed creature.  
Come on over here, dear friend—over here.<sup>21</sup>  
You show up as a saviour for the city  
and for the two of us.

SAUSAGE SELLER

What's going on?  
Why are you calling me?

DEMOSTHENES

Come over here, [150]  
so you can find out your enormous luck,  
how tremendously fortunate you are.

[*The Sausage Seller climbs up from the orchestra onto the stage with Demosthenes and Nicias.*]

NICIAS

Come on, take that table from him. Tell him  
what the god's oracle proclaims. I'll go  
and keep watch on the Paphlagonian.

210

[*Nicias exits into the house.*]

DEMOSTHENES

All right. First of all, set that equipment down  
on the ground here. And make a sacred salute  
to the earth and to the gods.<sup>22</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER [*carrying out those actions*]

There! What's going on?

DEMOSTHENES

O you most blest of men! And wealthy, too!

---

<sup>21</sup>The Greek says “up here,” because Demosthenes is on a stage, above the orchestra where the Sausage Seller enters.

<sup>22</sup>Merry notes that the salute would be with the thumb and forefinger touching the lips, a gesture made at a moment of great good fortune.

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Today you have nothing, but tomorrow  
you will be immensely great, chief leader  
of a happy Athens!

SAUSAGE SELLER

My good fellow,  
why not leave me alone to wash my tripe [160]  
and sell my sausages, instead of mocking me?

DEMOSTHENES

You silly fool! Forget about your tripe! 220  
Look over there. Do you see those people,  
all those rows?

SAUSAGE SELLER

I see them.

DEMOSTHENES

You're going to be  
lord and master of them all, in control  
of the marketplaces and the harbours  
and of the Pnyx. You'll stomp on the Council,  
keep generals in line, tie people up,  
throw them in jail—and in the Prytaneum  
you'll be sucking cocks.<sup>23</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

Me?

DEMOSTHENES

Yes, you of course.  
But you're not seeing the whole picture yet.  
Climb up on this table of yours—gaze out 230  
at all the islands there surrounding us. [170]

SAUSAGE SELLER [*climbs up on his table and looks out*]

I see them.

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<sup>23</sup>The Pnyx is a large amphitheatre west of the Acropolis in Athens where the Athenian assembly met. The Prytaneum was the symbolic centre of civic life, a building where a sacred fire was kept and important figures were entertained. Citizens who had given exceptional service to the state could gain the privilege of eating there at public expense. Sommerstein notes that the sexual depravity is a swipe at Athenian politicians and an indication of the Sausage Seller's fitness for public office, since he does not object to the gross insult which calls him, in effect, a public prostitute.



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DEMOSTHENES

What do you see? Trading ports?  
Merchant ships?

SAUSAGE SELLER

Yes. I see those.

DEMOSTHENES

All right then,  
how can you not be immensely fortunate?  
Now turn your right eye towards Caria  
and the other eye towards Carthage.<sup>24</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER [*in great physical discomfort*]

I'll be happy  
once I dislocate my neck!

DEMOSTHENES

That not the point.  
All that land is to be traded away,  
thanks to you. For you are going to be  
the most powerful of men—this oracle  
says so right here.

240

SAUSAGE SELLER

Then explain this to me—  
How am I, a seller of sausages,  
going to change to someone respectable?

DEMOSTHENES

The very reason you'll be powerful  
is that you're a shameless market rascal—  
and impudent, as well.

[180]

SAUSAGE SELLER

But I don't think  
I'm good enough to have great influence.

DEMOSTHENES

Good heavens, whatever is wrong with you

---

<sup>24</sup>Caria is a city on the east coast of Asia Minor, and Carthage is far to the west of Athens. The Sausage Seller is being asked to survey virtually the whole eastern and central Mediterranean. Neither Caria nor Carthage is part of the Athenian empire, but some ambitious politicians were hoping to extend that empire in both directions.

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to make you say you are not good enough?  
You must, I'm sure, know something remarkable  
about yourself. What about your parents?  
Don't you come from good and honest people?

250

SAUSAGE SELLER

By god no! Nothing but worthless rabble.

DEMOSTHENES

O you fine fellow! Such amazing luck!  
For political affairs you really have  
such great advantages!

SAUSAGE SELLER

But, my good man,  
I have no education, nothing but  
reading and writing, and I'm bad at those—  
real bad.

DEMOSTHENES

That's the only thing stopping you,  
that you can read and write, even poorly—  
real bad. You see, a leader of the people  
no longer needs to have any training  
or be honest in his dealings. Instead  
he should be ignorant and disgusting.  
But you must not disregard what the gods  
are offering to you in this oracle.

[190]  
260

SAUSAGE SELLER

What does the oracle say?

DEMOSTHENES

By the gods,  
it's good—but its style is rather intricate,  
written as a sophisticated riddle.

*[He reads the oracle in a solemn tone.]*

“But when the eagle tanner with his crooked claws  
shall in his beak seize the stupid, blood-sucking serpent,  
then will perish the Paphlagonian's pickled garlic,  
and then the gods will bestow enormous fame

270

## KNIGHTS

on those whose vocation is to market tripe  
unless they would prefer to sell their sausages.” [200]

SAUSAGE SELLER

How has this got anything to do with me?

DEMOSTHENES

Well, the eagle tanner is that man there—

*[Demosthenes points to Cleon sitting in the audience.]*

the Paphlagonian . . .

SAUSAGE SELLER

Those “crooked claws”—  
what are they?

DEMOSTHENES

What those words mean is clear.  
He seizes things in crooked hands, like claws, 280  
and confiscates them.

SAUSAGE SELLER

What about the serpent?

DEMOSTHENES

That’s obvious. The serpent is elongated,  
as is the sausage, which is also long.  
And sausages, like serpents, suck up blood.  
Hence, it says the serpent will now conquer  
the eagle tanner, unless the snake’s resolve  
is broken down by words.<sup>25</sup> [210]

SAUSAGE SELLER

Well, this oracle  
makes me sound good. Still, I’m wondering  
how I’ll be capable of ruling people.

DEMOSTHENES

That’s ridiculously easy. Keep doing 290  
what you’re doing. Make a complete hash

---

<sup>25</sup>This seems to mean, as Sommerstein points out, that the serpent-sausage maker will prevail, unless he is intimidated by Cleon’s bluster. Green notes (following Walsh) that the mention of blood suggests that the sausages may be more like black pudding than conventional sausages.

## KNIGHTS

of public business, mix things together  
like sausage meat, and always win people  
to your side with well-cooked little phrases  
to sweeten them. The other qualities  
a leader of the public really needs  
you have already—a disgusting voice  
and disreputable birth—and what's more,  
you're a product of the marketplace.  
You possess all the qualities essential 300  
for politics. The oracles agree,  
including Apollo's shrine at Delphi. [220]  
So crown yourself with a garland wreath,  
make a libation to the god of idiots,  
and then give that man what he deserves.

### SAUSAGE SELLER

Who is going to help me out? Rich men fear him,  
and poor men are so terrified they fart.

### DEMOSTHENES

But there are a thousand excellent men,  
the Knights, who hate him. They will assist you—  
along with the upright and honest men 310  
among the citizens, all people here  
in this audience who have any brains,  
and me. The god will help you out as well.  
Have no fear. You won't see a face like his— [230]  
the men who make the masks were just too scared  
to dare prepare something that looked like him.  
Still he'll be easy enough to recognize.  
This audience is smart enough for that!<sup>26</sup>

### NICIAS [*from inside*]

What the hell! The Paphlagonian—  
he's coming out! We're done for! 320

*[The Paphlagonian rushes out of the house.]*

---

<sup>26</sup>This is either a joke at Cleon's expense (his face is so hideous and terrifying that artists are too scared to create a likeness) or else, as Sommerstein suggests, Aristophanes may have had legal reasons for not depicting Cleon visually (or using his name in the play). Given the comic possibilities of a mask, it seems odd that one is not used for the Paphlagonian. According to tradition, Aristophanes may have played the part of the Paphlagonian himself with his face smeared with ochre and wine-lees.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN *[roaring]*

By the twelve gods, you won't get away with this—  
an ongoing conspiracy against the public!  
What going on with this Chalcidian cup?  
You must be stirring an insurgency  
among Chalcidians. You will be killed—  
you pair of polluted rogues—you will perish!<sup>27</sup>

*[The Sausage Seller backs away in terror.]*

DEMOSTHENES *[to the Sausage Seller]*

Hey, why are you backing off? Stand up to him! [240]  
O noble sausage seller, do not betray  
our public cause!

*[Demosthenes starts shouting at the Chorus off-stage in the wings.]*

You Knights, cavalry men,  
help us out—now is a time of crisis! 330  
Simon, Panaetius! Charge the right wing!

*[He goes to the Sausage Seller and turns him to face the Paphlagonian.]*

They're getting close. Come on, defend yourself!  
Wheel round for an attack! Their cloud of dust  
is clearly visible. They're coming on—  
almost here. So fight back! Chase him away!  
Get that Paphlagonian out of here!

*[Demosthenes pushes the Sausage Seller towards the Paphlagonian as the Chorus of Knights comes running in. They chase the Paphlagonian around the stage.]*

CHORUS LEADER

Hit him! Hit that wretch who spreads confusion  
among the cavalry! That tax collector!  
That gaping gulf of greed! That Charybdis!<sup>28</sup>  
Villain, villain, villain—I'll say that word 340  
again and again, for he's a villain  
many times a day! Beat him! Chase him off! [250]

---

<sup>27</sup>The cup Demosthenes has been using is made of silver from Chalcis. The Paphlagonian immediately concludes they must be fomenting a revolt against Athens in the region of Chalcis.

<sup>28</sup>Charybdis was a destructive whirlpool which sucked everything down into it. In *Odyssey* 12 it is an important hazard Odysseus and his crew must cope with.

## KNIGHTS

Keep after him! Don't give him any peace!  
Show you hate that man as much as we do,  
and shout out as you swarm all over him!  
Take care he doesn't get away from you.  
He knows the alleyways Eucrates took  
to scurry off back to the marketplace.<sup>29</sup>

PAPHLAGONIAN [*addressing the audience*]

You old jurymen, my three-obol brothers,  
whom I nourish with my raucous shouting  
of just and unjust things, help me out now!  
I'm being lambasted by conspirators. 350

CHORUS LEADER

And justly so! Because you gobble up  
public funds before you're picked for office,  
and when state officers submit accounts,  
you squeeze them, as if you were picking figs  
to see which ones are green and hard, or ripe, [260]  
or not yet fully seasoned.<sup>30</sup> And what's more,  
you keep your eye peeled for any citizen  
who's stupid as a sheep but has money 360  
and who's terrified of public business,  
and if you find one, some simple fool  
who avoids all politics, you haul him back  
from the Chersonese, then wrap him up  
in slanders, hook his knees, twist his shoulder,  
fall all over him, and swallow him up.<sup>31</sup>

PAPHLAGONIAN

You're attacking me as well? But, my good men,  
it's because of you I'm being beaten up—  
I was just on the point of proposing

---

<sup>29</sup>The precise meaning of this line is obscure. Merry notes that it might refer to the fact that Eucrates, once he was driven from political power by Cleon, went back to being a commercially successful bran merchant. Green suggests that it might be based on a well-known event when Eucrates escaped danger by hiding under a pile of bran.

<sup>30</sup>Outgoing public officials had to have their use of public money checked by an audit, a process which, so this states, Cleon abused.

<sup>31</sup>I follow Merry and Sommerstein and others in placing lines 264 and 265 of the Greek text between lines 260 and 261. The Chersonese is a distant region to the north-east of Athens, in Thrace. The suggestion seems to be that the Athenian citizen mentioned had gone there for a peaceful, non-political life.

## KNIGHTS

we ought to set up a memorial  
to your bravery here in the city. 370

*[The Chorus has moved to surround the Paphlagonian.]*

CHORUS LEADER *[threatening the Paphlagonian with his fist]*

O you impostor! You slippery rogue!  
See how he sweet talks and swindles us,  
as if we were senile old men? But if [270]  
he jumps this way, I'll thump him with this fist.  
If he slips down here my legs will kick him.

PAPHLAGONIAN *[appealing to the audience]*

O you people! O city! Look at this—  
savage beasts are pummelling my belly.

*[Demosthenes pushes the Sausage Seller into the crowd surrounding the Paphlagonian.]*

SAUSAGE SELLER

Ah, are you now rabble-rousing, the way  
you always do when bullying the city?<sup>32</sup> 380

PAPHLAGONIAN

With this loud voice of mine I'll make a start  
by forcing you to flee.

CHORUS LEADER

If your shouting  
defeats him, then bully for you—you win.  
But if his shamelessness surpasses yours,  
then the victory cake belongs to us.<sup>33</sup>

PAPHLAGONIAN *[pointing to the Sausage Seller]*

I denounce this man. I claim he smuggles soup  
out to the Peloponnesian warships!

SAUSAGE SELLER

And I, by god, am accusing this man [280]

---

<sup>32</sup>There is some doubt over the speaker of these lines. Along with other editors, I assign them to the Sausage Seller, since he must enter the argument at some point, and assigning this speech to the Chorus Leader, as the manuscript does, creates a staging problem.

<sup>33</sup>A honey cake was a prize at a drinking party for the best performer and for the one who stayed awake the longest.

## KNIGHTS

of running into the Prytaneum  
with an empty stomach, then coming out  
with his guts crammed full.

390

DEMOSTHENES

That's right, by god.  
And he carries off prohibited stuff—  
bread, meat, slices of fried fish. The people  
never considered Pericles worthy  
of that honour.<sup>34</sup>

*[The Paphlagonian and the Sausage Seller now get into a shouting match.]*

PAPHLAGONIAN

The two of you will die—  
right on the spot!

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll keep on screaming out  
three times as loud as you!

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll yell so loud  
I'll drown out your noise!

SAUSAGE SELLER

And when I bellow,  
your hollering will cease.

PAPHLAGONIAN

If you become  
a general, I'll smear your name with dirt.

400

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll thrash your back, as if you were a dog.

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll skin you alive with false accusations.

[290]

---

<sup>34</sup>Pericles was the political leader in Athens at the height of its glory. He died of the plague a year after war broke out. These lines apparently mean that he never received the honour of dining at public expense at the Prytaneum. They also suggest that whoever did have that honour was not entitled to take food away with him.



## KNIGHTS

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll use illegal ways to block your path.

PAPHLAGONIAN

Look me right in the eye. Try not to blink.

*[The Paphlagonian and the Sausage Seller are now engaged in a stare-down contest with very little distance between them.]*

SAUSAGE SELLER

I, too, was brought up in the marketplace.<sup>35</sup>

PAPHLAGONIAN

If you make a sound, I'll tear you apart.

SAUSAGE SELLER

Say a word and I'll stuff your mouth with shit.

*[Pause as they try to stare each other down. The Paphlagonian is the first to look away, straighten up, and continue.]*

PAPHLAGONIAN

I admit I'm a thief. You don't do that.

SAUSAGE SELLER

By Hermes of the marketplace, I do.  
And if anybody sees me stealing,  
I just lie—perjure myself under oath.

410

PAPHLAGONIAN

Then you're copying someone else's tricks—  
doing what I do! And I denounce you  
to the city council for possessing  
sacred tripe for which you've paid no taxes.<sup>36</sup>

[300]

CHORUS

You're a wretched, disreputable screamer!

*[They start a rhythmic chant around the Paphlagonian.]*

---

<sup>35</sup>In other words, I'm just as capable of putting a bold face on things as you are.

<sup>36</sup>The Greek uses the word *Prytanes*, which, as Sommerstein notes, is the business committee of the City Council. He also suggests that with the phrase "sacred tripe" the Paphlagonian may be stating that the Sausage Seller's wares are spoils of war and thus subject to tax.

## KNIGHTS

The whole world is full of your impudent snort—  
all meetings, all taxes, decrees, and the courts  
you stir up like mud and disrupt the town [310]  
and deafen our Athens by shouting us down. 420  
For money from tribute you take careful stock,  
like spying out tuna from high on a rock.<sup>37</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

I know what's going on here—it's been sliced out  
of an old piece of leather.

### SAUSAGE SELLER

Well, if you  
don't know a thing about cutting leather,  
then I know nothing about sausages.  
You're the one who used a misleading cut  
to slice leather from a crappy ox hide  
and cheated country folk by selling it,  
so before they'd worn it a single day, 430  
it had stretched and was two palm widths bigger.<sup>38</sup>

### DEMOSTHENES

Yes, by god, he did the same thing to me.  
It made me a huge laughing stock to friends [320]  
and neighbours. Before I'd reached Pergase,  
it was like I was swimming in my sandals.<sup>39</sup>

### CHORUS [*continuing their chant*]

And right from the start weren't you shameless as hell,  
the single protection for those who speak well?  
Relying on your crassness you squeeze money out  
from strangers with cash, for you've got all the clout.  
Hippodamus's son is watching in tears, 440  
but now someone else I like better appears.<sup>40</sup>

---

<sup>37</sup>Merry notes that in coastal regions people on land kept watch for shoals of tuna fish.

<sup>38</sup>The leather was cut obliquely so as to look thick and strong, but it was so bad it quickly expanded, and the shoes no longer fit.

<sup>39</sup>Pergase was a community close to Athens. Hence, the trip to it would be a short walk.

<sup>40</sup>Hippodamus's son is Archeptolemus, a well-known politician. From this reference it would appear that he is opposed to Cleon's aggressive war policies but is doing nothing about them. Merry mentions that Archeptolemus was probably in the audience, so that the phrase "watching in tears" takes on an added significance.

## KNIGHTS

He's more shameless by far, and he will win through— [330]  
his impudent swindles will clearly beat you.

CHORUS LEADER [*to the Sausage Seller*]  
All right, you who were brought up in that place  
where men worthy of the name come from,  
show us now how a decent upbringing  
doesn't mean a thing.<sup>41</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER  
Well, then you must hear  
what sort of citizen this fellow is.

PAPHLAGONIAN  
Will you let me speak?

SAUSAGE SELLER  
Of course, I won't,  
because I'm a low life, just like you. 450

DEMOSTHENES  
If he doesn't surrender on that point,  
tell him you come from a family of thieves.

PAPHLAGONIAN  
Are you going to allow me to speak?

SAUSAGE SELLER  
No, by god, I'm not!

PAPHLAGONIAN [*getting very angry*]  
Yes, by god, you will!

SAUSAGE SELLER  
No, by Poseidon, I won't. I'll fight first  
to see who will speak before the other.

PAPHLAGONIAN  
Bloody hell! I'm going to explode!

---

<sup>41</sup>The place where the "worthy" men are brought up now is, of course, the marketplace.

## KNIGHTS

SAUSAGE SELLER

No, you're not.

I won't allow it.

CHORUS LEADER

Let him burst, for god's sake—  
let him!

PAPHLAGONIAN

And what makes you so confident  
you think can confront me face to face? 460

SAUSAGE SELLER

Because I am capable of prattling on  
and of cooking up some spicy sauces.

PAHPLAGONIAN

So you can speak! Bah! If some business matter—  
a ripped-up bloody mess—fell in your lap  
and you grabbed it, you'd handle it so well!  
O yes, you'd arrange things with such expertise!  
You know what I think has happened to you?  
Like many others, I suppose you gave  
a pretty speech in a petty lawsuit  
against some foreign resident.<sup>42</sup> You rehearsed 470  
it all night long and babbled it to yourself  
in the streets, slurping water, practising  
to friends and irritating them with it.  
And now you think you can speak in public. [350]  
You fool! You've mad!

SAUSAGE SELLER

What have you been drinking?  
You've turned the city into a place where you,  
all by yourself, shout everybody down  
and silence them.

PAPHLAGONIAN

Can you find any man  
to rival me? I'll gobble up slices  
of hot tuna and wash that down with wine— 480

---

<sup>42</sup>Merry notes that winning a case in court against a foreigner was probably easier than winning one against an Athenian citizen.

## KNIGHTS

a full jug and unmixed—and after that  
I'll bugger those generals at Pylos.

### SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll swallow a ox stomach and pig tripe  
and after that gulp down the sauce, as well—  
then without bothering to wash myself  
I'll drown the politicians with my shouts  
and put Nicias in a tizzy.

### DEMOSTHENES

I do like  
what you just said, but there is one thing  
I'm not happy with—you're going to slurp  
all the political gravy by yourself.

490 [360]

### PAPHLAGONIAN

But you're not going to stuff yourself with sea bass  
from Miletus and later blow them off.<sup>43</sup>

### SAUSAGE SELLER

But I will dine on beef ribs. After that,  
I'll buy up leases on some silver mines.<sup>44</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll use force to jump into the Council—  
make them all panic.

### SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll stuff your arse hole—  
just like a sausage skin.

### PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll force you outside  
by your buttocks—head down through the door.

### DEMOSTHENES

If you're going to drag him outside, by god,  
then you'll have to haul me out there, as well.

500

---

<sup>43</sup>Miletus was famous for its sea bass. Sommerstein suggests the speech may have something to do with Cleon's accepting a bribe from the Milesians and then ignoring them.

<sup>44</sup>The rich silver mines in Attica were owned by the state but leased to individuals. The implication is that he will use his political influence to make himself very rich.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN

How I'll clap you in the stocks!

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll denounce you  
as a bloody coward!

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll stretch your hide  
across my tanning bench.

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll skin you alive—  
turn you into a robber's belly bag.

PAPHLAGONIAN

You'll be pegged down—at full stretch on the ground.

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll slice you up, grind you into mincemeat.

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll pluck out your eyelashes.

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll slice your throat.

DEMOSTHENES

By god, we'll force a peg inside his mouth,  
like cooks do with pigs, then tear out his tongue,  
and peer down past his gaping jaws to see  
if there are any pimples up his ass.<sup>45</sup>

510 [380]

CHORUS

There are things in the city, it's clear from this case,  
which are hotter than fire, more full of disgrace  
than those scandalous speeches all over the place.  
This issue matters—it's not just cheap smut,  
so let's go at this man, twist him by his butt—  
no room for half measures now we've grabbed his gut.

---

<sup>45</sup>Cooks checked on the health of a pig by forcing its mouth open, pushing its tongue aside, and checking for spots. An unsatisfactory pig, Merry notes, had white spots. Here the sense is that if they followed this procedure with Cleon, they'll be able to see right down to his anus to check it for disease.

## KNIGHTS

*[The Chorus seizes the Paphlagonian.]*

### CHORUS LEADER

If you wear him down now with a thrashing,  
you'll find he's a coward. I know his style. [390]

### SAUSAGE SELLER

He's been that sort of fellow all his life, 520  
but these days he thinks he's a real man  
for harvesting someone else's grain crop.  
And now he's tied that crop up in prison,  
the ears of grain he carried back from there—  
he's drying them out and wants to sell them.<sup>46</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

I'm not afraid of you, not while the Senate  
is alive and kicking and the people  
just sit around looking like total fools.

### CHORUS

Whatever happens he has no shame.  
His colour always remains the same. 530  
If you're not a fellow that I despise,  
let me be spread out under the thighs  
of Cratinus as his piss-soaked fleece, [400]  
or may I be taught to sing a piece  
by Morsimus, some tragical song.<sup>47</sup>  
You pest, you're always buzzing along,  
searching about all around town,  
wherever you go, and settling down  
on bribery blooms. O may you please  
vomit mouthfuls of cash with the same ease 540  
you swallowed them down—for then I would sing  
“Drink, let us drink—it's such a good thing!”

---

<sup>46</sup>The grain crop is a reference to the Spartan prisoners captured in the victory in the Peloponnese (for which Cleon saw to it that he received all the credit). He had these men (120 in all) brought back to Athens and thrown into prison under desperate conditions, without sufficient water or food. The suggestion here is that he is negotiating to ransom them for profit.

<sup>47</sup>Cratinus, a successful comic poet, is a frequent target of Aristophanic satire. He was, by reputation, a notorious drinker. Hence, the fleece or blanket on which he slept would be frequently soaked in urine. I have made that reference more explicit than it is in the Greek (by adding the phrase about the thighs). Morsimus was a tragic poet Aristophanes often attacks for his wretched poetry.

## KNIGHTS

### CHORUS LEADER

And Ulius, I think, who checks grain, too,  
and keeps his eye cruising for lads to screw,  
would sing out to Bacchus, “O god, thank you.”<sup>48</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

By Poseidon, you will not outdo me  
in shamelessness. If you do, may I never  
have any part of those offerings of meat  
to Zeus, god of our public meeting place!<sup>49</sup> [410]

### SAUSAGE SELLER

And I swear by the many fists whose thrashings 550  
I’ve had so often since I was a kid  
and by the cuts from butcher’s knives, I know  
in this business I will outperform you.  
If not, there’d be no point in being so large  
after eating nothing but finger wipes.<sup>50</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

You mean bread for wiping hands, just like a dog?  
You silly fool, on a diet of dog food  
how will you battle a dog-faced baboon?

### SAUSAGE SELLER

By god, my youth has taught me other tricks.  
I’d swindle the butchers by saying things like, 560  
“Hey lads, take a look. You see that swallow?  
Springtime is here!” And when they’d look up,  
right then I’d snatch off some of their meat. [420]

### DEMOSTHENES

O cleverest of men! You planned that well—

---

<sup>48</sup>The reference here is obscure. The best conjecture is that the lines refer to someone called Ulius, a man in charge of checking wheat supplies, who was a lover of young boys. In the Greek there is possibly a pun involved on “watching the grain” and “looking out for boys.” Ulius will be happy if Cleon repents, because then less food will be stolen. Sommerstein points out that there is historical evidence for a man called Ulius of about the right age.

<sup>49</sup>The offerings to Zeus were part of the rites performed in honour of Zeus at the opening of the Public Assembly. The statement indicates that the Paphlagonian would no longer take part in the Assembly (i.e., give up political life).

<sup>50</sup>Diners cleaned their fingers by wiping them on pieces of bread, which were then fed to dogs.



## KNIGHTS

like those who eat nettles, you stole your meat  
before the swallows came.<sup>51</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

And I did it  
without being noticed! If one of them saw,  
I'd hide the stuff—shove it in my butt crack  
and swear by the gods I'd done nothing wrong.  
When some politician saw what I did, 570  
he said, "There's no doubt about it—this child  
is someone who will rule the people."

DEMOSTHENES

What he said was right. And it's very clear  
what led him to arrive at that opinion—  
you could steal, perjure yourself, and shove meat  
way up your ass.

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll stop this man's insolence—  
or rather, I'll put an end to both of you.  
I'll come at the two of you, sweeping down 430  
with a driving mighty wind, confounding  
land and sea into a common chaos. 580

SAUSAGE SELLER

At that point I'll haul in my sausages,  
and let my ship sail before the friendly breeze,  
while telling you to wail and howl away.

DEMOSTHENES

I'll watch out for the bilges, just in case  
we start to spring a leak.

PAPHLAGONIAN

By Demeter,  
you're not going to get away with stealing  
so many talents from the Athenians!

DEMOSTHENES [*pretending he's on a ship*]

Keep your eyes peeled! Ease off on the sail rope!

---

<sup>51</sup>Merry notes that nettles in salad were tasty only at the very beginning of spring. The Athenians made much of the arrival of the first swallows, a sign of the arrival of spring.

## KNIGHTS

There's a north-east wind starting to blow in  
a storm of accusations!

SAUSAGE SELLER

I understand 590  
you took ten talents from Potidaea.<sup>52</sup>

PAPHLAGONIAN

What about it? Would you like one talent  
to keep your mouth shut?

*[The Paphlagonian offers the Sausage Seller a bag of money.]*

DEMOSTHENES *[grabbing the money]*

He'd be happy to take it. [440]  
Slacken the main brace! The wind's easing off.

PAPHLAGONIAN

You'll be charged [with bribery]—four lawsuits—  
each one carries a hundred talent fine.<sup>53</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

You'll be charged with twenty for skipping out  
on military service—and thousands more  
for theft.

PAPHLAGONIAN

I claim you are a descendant  
of those who carried out a sacrilege 600  
against our goddess.<sup>54</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

And your grandfather,  
I proclaim, was one of the bodyguards . . .

---

<sup>52</sup>Potidaea was a city which had surrendered to Athens some years before after a long siege. The accusation is that the Paphlagonian accepted a huge bribe to argue for more generous peace terms. A talent was worth many thousands of dollars in today's money.

<sup>53</sup>Part of the line is missing. I follow Sommerstein's suggestion for the missing words. The inserted phrase is in square brackets.

<sup>54</sup>The Paphlagonian is accusing the Sausage Seller that he comes from an aristocratic family who, many years before, had murdered some political refugees who had taken refuge in the Temple of Athena, after promising them safety. The family was still considered under a curse.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN

What bodyguards? Tell us.

SAUSAGE SELLER

. . . to Bursina,  
who was wife of Hippias the tyrant.<sup>55</sup>

PAMPHLAGONIAN

You're a total rogue!

SAUSAGE SELLER

And you're a scoundrel. [450]

*[The Sausage Seller threatens to hit the Paphlagonian with a string of sausages.]*

DEMOSTHENES

Hit him! Give him a hefty swipe!

*[The Sausage Seller starts hitting the Paphlagonian with his sausages.]*

PAPHLAGONIAN

Oooowww! That hurts!  
These conspirators are assaulting me!

DEMOSTHENES

Hit him as hard as you can! And lash him  
on the stomach with your tripe and guts.  
Punch him in that paunch of his!

*[The Paphlagonian sinks down under the assault by the Sausage Seller.]*

CHORUS LEADER *[to the Sausage Seller]*

You brave heart! 610  
The noblest of all slabs of meat! You show up  
as a saviour for our city and for us,  
its citizens—how well, how brilliantly  
your speeches have demoralized that man.  
What praise for you can match the joy we feel? [460]

---

<sup>55</sup>Hippias, who ruled Athens at the end of the 6th century (i.e., long before), was a tyrant. He remained a symbol of anti-democratic practices. His wife's name was Myrsine. The change of name to Bursina, Green suggests, may be an attempt at a pun on *bursa*, the Greek word for *hide*, a reference to Cleon's business in leather.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN [*pulling himself together and getting up*]

By Demeter, I was not unaware  
of this conspiracy they were framing.  
I knew what they were nailing together  
and hammering into one—the whole scheme!

SAUSAGE SELLER

And I'm not unaware of what you're doing  
in Argos. He pretends he's making Argives  
our friends, but he's negotiating there  
with Spartans—one of his private deals.<sup>56</sup> 620

DEMOSTHENES

Come on, aren't you going to use any words  
to match his language from the building trades?<sup>57</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

And I know why the bellows are blowing—  
they're forging something for the prisoners.<sup>58</sup>

DEMOSTHENES

Good! O that's good! His carpentry answered  
with phrases from the blacksmith's forge. [470]

SAUSAGE SELLER

There are men  
in Sparta hammering at it as well. 630  
But if you offer me gold or silver  
or send your friends around, you won't stop me  
announcing this to all Athenians.

PAPHLAGONIAN

Well, I'm going to the Council right away  
to inform them of the conspiracies  
involving all of you—those meetings

---

<sup>56</sup>Argos, an important city state in the central Peloponnese, was officially neutral at the start of the war. Winning that state to one's cause would be a natural and important strategy.

<sup>57</sup>Demosthenes is upset because the Sausage Seller has not responded to the Paphlagonian's use of the language of carpentry. The Greek uses the word meaning "wheelwright." I have substituted a more general term ("building trades"). The placement of this line varies, but, as Merry and Sommerstein and others note, this seems to be the most obvious place for it.

<sup>58</sup>The allegation here is that Cleon is arranging some private deal for the ransom of the Spartan prisoners mentioned earlier (the ones he had brought back to Athens after the Athenian victory in the Peloponnese).

## KNIGHTS

you have in the city during the night,  
all your secret dealings with the Persians  
and their Great King and how you're making hay  
with the Boeotians.<sup>59</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

Ah, hay in Boeotia! 640 [480]  
What's the going rate for hay?

PAPHLAGONIAN *[exasperated]*

By Hercules,  
I'll stretch that hide of yours!

*[The Paphlagonian leaves, moving toward the city.]*

DEMOSTHENES *[to Sausage Seller]*

Come on now!  
What sort of brain and heart do you possess?  
Now's the time to show if you really hid  
that meat inside your butt crack way back when,  
the way you say you did. You've got to dash  
to the Council rooms—running all the way.  
That man is about to descend on them  
and slander every one of us, howling  
and kicking up a fuss.

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'm going. But first, 650  
I'll get rid of my tripe and sausages—  
I'll leave them here.

DEMOSTHENES

Hang on! Rub some of this grease [490]  
on your neck and throat, so you can slide out  
from his false charges.

SAUSAGE SELLER

Excellent advice—  
spoken like a wrestling master.

---

<sup>59</sup>The general Demosthenes had been involved in negotiations with democratic citizens in the city state of Boeotia, trying to win that region over to the Athenian cause. Cleon is accusing him of consorting with the enemy. I have used the phrase “making hay” (meaning “work for one’s own advantage”) in place of the Greek verb which refers to making cheese.

## KNIGHTS

DEMOSTHENES [*rubbing meat grease on the Sausage Seller*]  
All right.

Now take this and swallow it!

SAUSAGE SELLER

What is it?

DEMOSTHENES

You'll fight better when you're stuffed with garlic.  
Hurry up! Get a move on!<sup>60</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

That's what I'm doing!

[*The Sausage Seller leaves in the same direction as the Paphlagonian.*]

DEMOSTHENES [*shouting after the Sausage Seller*]

Remember now—bite the man, slander him,  
eat up his coxcomb. Don't come back here 660  
until you've gobbled his wattles.

CHORUS LEADER [*in the direction of the Sausage Seller*]

Go and good luck!

May you live up to my hopes, and may Zeus [500]  
god of our public meetings, protect you,  
and may you come back to us in triumph,  
adorned with the garlands of victory.

[*Demosthenes exits into the house. The Chorus Leader turns to address the audience.*]

Now pay attention to our formal verse,  
you who have on your own already heard  
all the different offerings of the Muse.<sup>61</sup>  
If one of the comic playwrights from long ago  
had tried to make us step out to this audience 670  
and recite a speech, it would not have been easy  
for him to get his way. But today our poet  
is worth the effort, because he hates the same men

---

<sup>60</sup>Fighting cocks were given garlic to make them fight more aggressively. Demosthenes continues the metaphor of the cockfight in his next speech.

<sup>61</sup>In this passage, which announces a shift in tone to a more serious passage, the Greek says "listen to our anapaests." But since that is not the rhythm in the English, I have substituted "formal verse" and switched to hexameters.

## KNIGHTS

we despise and dares to speak the truth, charging [510]  
 courageously against typhoon and hurricane.  
 He says that many of you have come up to him  
 astonished that he did not long ago request  
 a chorus in his own name and questioning him  
 about it. He has asked us to explain to you  
 why this has happened.<sup>62</sup> He asserts that it was not 680  
 foolishness that prompted his delay but rather  
 that he considered producing comic drama  
 the most difficult task of all. Many people try  
 to court the Comic Muse, but she grants her favours  
 only to a few. And he has long recognized  
 that you have a fickle nature—for you betrayed  
 earlier poets once they grew old. He knows well  
 what Magnes went through as soon as his hair turned white.<sup>63</sup> [520]  
 He had hoisted many trophies of victory  
 over his rivals, and though he had created 690  
 every kind of sound for your delight, by singing,  
 flapping his wings, performing as a Lydian  
 or a gnat, or smearing himself green as a frog,  
 that was not enough. In his youth things turned out well,  
 but at the end, in old age, you hissed him away,  
 that old man, whose jokes had lost their satiric bite.<sup>64</sup>  
 After that, our poet brought to mind Cratinus,  
 who once, flowing on torrents of your approval,  
 raced through unencumbered plains and, as he sped on,  
 uprooted oak and plane trees and his rivals, too, 700  
 and carried them away.<sup>65</sup> And at drinking parties  
 the only songs were “O Goddess of Bribery,  
 with sandals made of figs,” and “O you composers  
 of intricate hymns”—that’s how famous he was then.<sup>66</sup> [530]  
 But look at him now—he’s a decrepit old man.  
 His tuning pegs are gone, his tone has disappeared,

---

<sup>62</sup>Aristophanes’s earlier plays were produced by other people and not under his own name. Usually a playwright would request the appropriate official to name a sponsor who would pay for the production.

<sup>63</sup>Mages was an earlier comic poet who had recently died.

<sup>64</sup>Merry notes that Magnes had written plays featuring harp players, birds, frogs, Lydians, and gall flies.

<sup>65</sup>Cratinus (519 BC to 422 BC) was an important comic playwright and rival of Aristophanes.

<sup>66</sup>The “sandals of figs” is a parody of a Homeric phrase “sandals of gold.” And the phrase contains in Greek an allusion to *sycophant* (meaning a *servile flatterer*), a word put together from *sykon* (*fig*) and *phanein* (*show*).

## KNIGHTS

his joints have split apart, yet you don't pity him.  
He wanders around in his dotage, like Connas,  
wearing a withered garland and dying of thirst.<sup>67</sup>  
Given his previous triumphs, he should be drinking 710  
in the Prytaneum, and instead of acting  
like an idiot, he should be sitting smartly groomed  
with the spectators alongside Dionysus.<sup>68</sup>  
Look at how much Crates suffered from your abuse  
and anger, a man who used to provide you snacks  
for not much money and then send you home again,  
coming up with the most elegant conceptions  
from his decorous lips.<sup>69</sup> But he kept persisting,  
on his own, sometimes with success, sometimes failing. [540]  
Fearing such treatment, our poet kept on stalling. 720  
What's more, he would tell himself he should first of all  
work the oars before his hand could grip the tiller,  
and later he'd watch from the prow to check the winds—  
only after that would he be his own pilot.  
For all these reasons, he moved with great prudence,  
not rushing in like a fool and babbling nonsense.  
So raise a cheer for the man, a powerful surge  
with all of your fingers, a generous urge  
at our feast of Lenaea, so that our poet  
leaves here with joy and success and can know it— 730  
his forehead all bright with glistening delight.<sup>70</sup> [550]

## CHORUS

O Poseidon, lord of horses  
who rejoices in horses' neighs,  
in the clatter of bronze-shod hooves,  
in swift triremes with deep-blue prows  
transporting tribute on the sea,  
in contests where those youthful lads  
who seek fame by racing chariots

---

<sup>67</sup>Connus was a well-known and successful musician who, in his old age, was very poor.

<sup>68</sup>The name Dionysus refers to a statue of the god in the theatre.

<sup>69</sup>Crates was a successful writer of comic dramas. There is a suggestion (as Sommerstein observes) here that Crates's productions were relatively cheap and insufficiently ribald.

<sup>70</sup>The Lenaeon feast is the festival at which the comic dramas were staged. The reference to the poet's forehead may be a reference to Aristophanes' baldness. The Greek here involves an elliptical metaphor taken from rowing, in which the audience is urged to applaud with "eleven oars." Green suggests this may refer to a galley with eleven oars on each side used in a naval escort honouring someone. I have substituted the phrase "all of your fingers."



## KNIGHTS

can suffer catastrophic spills,  
 come to us here, to your chorus, 740  
 O god of the golden trident,  
 you who watches over dolphins, [560]  
 who are worshipped at Sunium,  
 lord of Geraestus, son of Cronos,  
 dearest favourite of Phormio,  
 and for Athenians the god  
 more beloved than all the others,  
 the one our present crisis needs.<sup>71</sup>

### CHORUS LEADER

We wish to sing the praises of our ancestors,  
 men worthy of this land who deserved to carry 750  
 the ceremonial robe.<sup>72</sup> In battles fought on land  
 or on the sea they were victorious all the time,  
 wherever they went—they brought our city honour.  
 And when they viewed their enemies, none of them  
 ever counted up their number. Instead, their hearts  
 at once were ready for the fray. If they fell down [570]  
 on their shoulder in a fight, they wiped off the dust  
 and denied they'd had a fall. Then they would resume  
 and fight on once again. No earlier general  
 would have asked Cleaenetus to serve him dinner 760  
 at state expense.<sup>73</sup> But now they say they will not fight  
 unless they get the privilege of front-row seats  
 and meals, as well. As for us, we believe we should  
 nobly guard our city and our country's gods  
 without being paid. We ask for nothing beyond that,  
 except this one condition: if peace ever comes  
 and brings our hard work to an end, you will not mind  
 if we wear long hair and keep our skin well scrubbed.<sup>74</sup> [580]

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<sup>71</sup>Sunium and Geraestus were promontories, important landmarks for sailors. Phormio was a very successful Athenian naval commander. The Athenian supremacy at sea was one of their most important military advantages in the war with the Spartans.

<sup>72</sup>At the Panathenaea festival a sacred robe was carried in a procession to the temple of Athena in the Acropolis, where it was placed on the statue of the goddess.

<sup>73</sup>None of the older generals would have expected to be rewarded with free meals at the Prytaneum. Now, generals try to get that privilege through Cleaenetus, Cleon's father.

<sup>74</sup>Long hair was fashionable among rich young men who made up the ranks of the Knights and a sign of social snobbery. Keeping the body well scrubbed is a sign of frequent bathing and, Merry suggests, might be considered effeminate.

## KNIGHTS

### CHORUS

O Pallas, guardian of our city,  
shielding this most sacred place, 770  
surpassing every land in war,  
in poetry, and in her might,  
come to us here and bring with you  
the one who in campaigns and fights  
stands there beside us, Victory,  
companion in our choral songs,  
who wars with us against our foes. [590]  
Now show yourself before us here.  
For if there ever was a time  
when you must give a victory 780  
by any means to these men here  
that moment has arrived.<sup>75</sup>

### CHORUS LEADER

We know our horses well and wish to praise them.  
They are worthy of our tributes, for along with us  
they have endured so many battles and attacks.  
But we admire them not so much for these events  
as for the time they bravely jumped on board the ships,  
once they had purchased drinking cups—and some of them [600]  
got garlic, too, and onions.<sup>76</sup> Then they grabbed the oars,  
just as we humans do, pulled hard on them, shouting, 790  
“Horses, heave! Who’s doing the rowing? Pull back harder!  
What are we doing? Hey you, you pedigree nag,  
why aren’t you rowing?” They disembarked at Corinth.  
The youngest then dug resting places with their hooves  
and went to bring back blankets. Instead of clover,  
they fed themselves on crabs if any scuttled up  
onshore, or else they caught them on the ocean floor,  
so that Theorus said a Corinthian crab  
would cry, “O Poseidon, what a cruel misfortune  
if I cannot evade those knights either by land, 800 [610]  
or even in the ocean depths, or on the sea.”<sup>77</sup>

---

<sup>75</sup>The victory mentioned refers to the competition to win first place in the drama contest.

<sup>76</sup>Here the chorus of Knights imagines that the horses have human qualities so that they can pay tribute, in effect, to themselves.

<sup>77</sup>The Chorus here is referring to a cavalry expedition against Corinth, an ally of Sparta, in the previous year. It is not clear who Theorus was. Sommerstein suggests he may be an associate of Cleon’s. Green states that the word *crab* was a derogatory label for a *Corinthian*.

## KNIGHTS

*[The Sausage Seller enters, returning from the city.]*

### CHORUS LEADER

O dearest and most vigorous of men,  
how worried I have been since you've been gone.  
Now you're back again safe and sound, tell us  
how did you make out in the competition?

### SAUSAGE SELLER

The result is this—I've crushed the Council.

### CHORUS

Then everyone now  
should shout with delight!  
You speak very well  
but your actions excite  
much more than your words. 810  
So come on, lay out  
in very clear terms  
what you've been about.  
I really believe  
I'd go a long way 620  
to hear what it is  
that you have to say.  
My very dear chap,  
be brave and tell all— 820  
each one of us gets  
such joy from your gall.

### SAUSAGE SELLER

Well then listen. The story is worth hearing.  
I went rushing from here right behind him.  
He was inside bursting with verbiage,  
hurling his thunder, attacking the Knights  
with fantastic stories, mountains of words,  
shouting they were conspirators—his speech  
was very convincing. The whole Council,  
as it listened to his lies, grew spice hot, 830 [630]  
with gazes like mustard and eyebrows tense.  
When I saw they believed what he was saying  
and were falling for his lies and bull crap,  
I said, "Come on, spirits of impudence,  
you cheats, you boobies, you rogues and rascals,  
and the Market, too, where I was brought up

## KNIGHTS

as a child, give me boundless brazenness,  
 a salesman's chatter, and a shameless voice."  
 As I was saying this to myself, a man  
 whose arse hole had been bugged out of shape 840  
 let rip a fart to my right, an omen  
 from the gods for which I gave them thanks.<sup>78</sup>  
 I banged the barrier and knocked it over [640]  
 with my bum, opened my mouth really wide,  
 and shouted out, "Members of the Council,  
 I bring excellent news, and I am keen  
 you be the first to hear it: since the time  
 this war broke over us, I've never seen  
 sardines at a cheaper price."<sup>79</sup> Their faces  
 immediately relaxed—they were prepared 850  
 to crown me for my good news. So I said,  
 as if I were telling them a secret,  
 that in order to buy lots of sardines  
 for just one obol, they should with all speed  
 confiscate all bowls from pottery shops. [650]  
 They looked at me with their mouths wide open  
 and applauded.<sup>80</sup> But the Paphlagonian,  
 guessing what I was up to and knowing  
 the kind of talk the Council really loved,  
 made a proposal, "Gentlemen, I think, 860  
 in honour of this wonderful event  
 which has just been reported, we should now  
 offer a sacrifice to the goddess—  
 one hundred oxen for this happy news."  
 The Council then swung back his way again.  
 So when I noticed I was being beaten  
 by his bullshit, I upped the ante on him  
 by shouting out, "Two hundred oxen!"  
 And then I suggested they make a vow  
 to Artemis, offering a thousand goats 870 [660]  
 the following day if the price of sardines  
 was a single obol for a hundred fish.  
 The Council was looking my way once more,  
 and eagerly. The Paphlagonian,

---

<sup>78</sup>This remark is parodying Homer, where thunder on the right is a favourable message from the gods.

<sup>79</sup>The barrier separated the public from the members of the Council.

<sup>80</sup>If there were no bowls available for the public, then people would not purchase sardines, because they would have no way of transporting them, and thus the price would stay low.

## KNIGHTS

when he heard what I had said, was stunned—  
he started to prattle raving nonsense.  
So then the presidents and the archers  
began to drag him off.<sup>81</sup> The Council members  
stood around babbling on about sardines.  
The Paphlagonian kept pleading with them,  
saying, “Wait a little, so you can hear  
what the Spartan messenger has to say.  
He’s arrived here with a peace proposal.”  
But with one voice the Councillors all cried,  
“Why sue for a treaty now? My dear fellow,  
it’s because they’ve learned our sardines are so cheap.  
We don’t want treaties! Let the war go on!”  
They called for the presidents to adjourn  
the assembly and then jumped the railing  
in all directions. I snuck off quickly  
to buy up all the coriander seed  
and onions on sale in the marketplace.  
Then I passed them all around free of charge  
as seasonings, a gift to Councillors,  
who had no spices to put on their fish.  
They all sang my praises and lavished me  
with their attention. So I won over  
all the Council with some coriander—  
an obol’s worth! Then I came back here.

880

[670]

890

[680]

## CHORUS

In all of these things  
you’ve been very good,  
getting your way  
as a lucky man should.  
The rascal’s now knows  
that he’s met defeat—  
another man beat him  
at being a cheat,  
a far greater rogue,  
with many more tricks,  
and intricate lies,  
and smooth talk that sticks.  
You need to take care  
to come off the best

900

910

---

<sup>81</sup>The Presidents (*Prytaneis*) were a special committee of 50 members of the Council. The archers were the security forces guarding the Council.

## KNIGHTS

when you fight once again  
and are put to the test.  
You've known for a while  
that we are a friend,  
your trustworthy ally  
right to the end.

[690]

*[The Paphlagonian enters, returning from the city.]*

SAUSAGE SELLER

Ah ha! Here comes the Paphlagonian,  
driving an fearful swell in front of him,  
seething and foaming, as if he's ready  
to swallow me up. My goodness, he's brash!

920

PAPHLAGONIAN

If I have any of my old lies left,  
I'll wipe you out—otherwise I'm done for,  
completely up the creek!

SAUSAGE SELLER

I love your threats!  
Your smoke-and-mirror chatter makes me laugh  
and dance a horny jig—the chicken dance!

*[The Sausage Seller taunts the Paphlagonian by imitating a chicken—flapping his arms, hopping around, and making chicken-like noises.]*

PAPHLAGONIAN

By Demeter, if I don't eat you up,  
kick you out of here, I'll never survive.

930

SAUSAGE SELLER

If you don't eat me up? And I won't live,  
if I don't drink you down and then explode  
with you stuffed in my guts.

[700]

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll destroy you—  
I swear that by the privileged seating  
I won by my victory at Pylos.

SAUSAGE SELLER

My, my—privileged seating! How I long

## KNIGHTS

to see you tossed from your privileged seat  
and sitting in a row right at the back.

PAPHLAGONIAN

By heaven, I'll have you clapped in the stocks!

SAUSAGE SELLER

What a nasty temper! Now, let me see—  
what can I give you to eat? What nourishment  
would you find truly sweet? Why not this purse?

940

*[The Sausage Seller holds up a purse and jingles the coins in front of the Paphlagonian.]*

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll eviscerate you with my nails!

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll pare down your Prytaneum dinners!

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll drag you to Demos—I'll have justice  
from you!

SAUSAGE SELLER

Then I'll haul you off to him—  
I can produce more slanders than you can.

PAPHLAGONIAN

You poor idiot! He won't believe you.  
I play around with him just as I wish.

SAUSAGE SELLER

You think of Demos as someone you own.

950

PAPHLAGONIAN

It's because I know all the finger foods  
he likes to nibble.

SAUSAGE SELLER

Yes, but you feed him  
like a dishonest nurse—you chew the food,  
then give him a small piece, once you've swallowed  
three times as much yourself.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN

Besides, with my skill,  
I can make Demos do whatever I want— [720]  
I can open him up or close him tight.<sup>82</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

Well, I can do that, too—with my arse hole.

PAPHLAGONIAN

Well, my dear fellow, you won't be a man  
who's known to have showered me with insults 960  
there in the Council. Let's go to Demos.

SAUSAGE SELLER

There's nothing to stop us. So come on then.

*[The Sausage Seller moves towards the door of the house, beckoning the Paphlagonian over.]*

Get moving. We should not hold back.

*[The Sausage Seller and the Paphlagonian move to the door of the house and begin knocking on it.]*

PAPHLAGONIAN *[calling into the house through the door]*

Demos!

Come on out here!

SAUSAGE SELLER *[calling into the house]*

Yes, father, for Zeus's sake,  
come outside!

PAPHLAGONIAN

Come out, dearest little Demos—  
so you can see how I am being abused.

DEMOS *[coming from the house]*

Who's doing all the shouting? Get out of here—

---

<sup>82</sup>The Greek says, "I can make Demos wide or narrow." Sommerstein points out that this must be a proverbial expression meaning "I can do anything I like with Demos."



## KNIGHTS

leave my doorway! You've torn this apart,  
my harvest wreath.<sup>83</sup>

*[Demos recognizes the Paphlagonian.]*

Ah, Paphlagonian,  
who's being nasty to you?

PAPHLAGONIAN

Because of you 970 [730]  
I'm being assaulted by this fellow here  
and by these young men.

DEMOS

Why is that?

PAPHLAGONIAN

Because I am your loving friend, Demos,  
and am very fond of you.

DEMOS *[to the Sausage Seller]*

And who are you?

SAUSAGE SELLER

I am this man's rival. For a long time  
I have loved you and wished to help you out—  
along with many other fine good people.  
But we have not been able to do that,  
because of this man here. You're like those lads  
who play around with lovers, refusing 980  
worthy, decent men and giving yourself  
to lamp dealers, cobblers, shoemakers,  
and men who trade in leather. [740]

PAPHLAGONIAN

Yes, because  
I am good for Demos.

SAUSAGE SELLER

All right, tell me  
just what do you do for him?

---

<sup>83</sup>The harvest wreath, Merry explains, is a garland of twigs and olive and wool interwoven with fruits and berries. It was used in certain festivals and then placed on the front door.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN

What do I do?

When the generals were dithering around,  
I sailed in there and then brought those Spartans  
back from Pylos.

SAUSAGE SELLER

And I, while strolling around,  
stole a boiling pot from someone else's shop.

PAPLAGONIAN

Demos, summon an assembly right now  
to find out which one of the two of us  
is more friendly to you. And then decide,  
so you can make that man the one you love. 990

SAUSAGE SELLER

Yes, do that. Make a choice. Just don't do it  
at the Pnyx.

DEMOS

I would not sit in judgment  
in any other place. So we must move  
up there. You must appear before the Pnyx. [750]

*[They all move over to a rock on one side of the orchestra. Demos sits down on the rock.]*

SAUSAGE SELLER *[aside, as they move]*

Bloody hell, I've had now. The old man  
is very sensible when he's at home,  
but whenever he sits down on that rock  
he's a gaping idiot, just like some child  
trying to catch figs with its mouth wide open.<sup>84</sup> 1000

CHORUS *[to the Sausage Seller]*

Now you must spread out all your sail—  
keep your spirit strong. Do not fail  
in argument. Beat down that man.  
He's tricky—always with a plan

---

<sup>84</sup>It is not entirely clear what this metaphor refers to. Whatever the reference, the comparison involves a picture of open-mouthed stupidity.

## KNIGHTS

when he seems done for. So attack  
like a raging wind. Don't hold back! [760]

### CHORUS LEADER

But take care! Before he closes in on you,  
first hoist your lead weights into position, 1010  
then run your ship at him along the side.<sup>85</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

I pray to lady Athena, who guards  
our city, that if I have been the best  
at serving the Athenian citizens—  
apart from Lysicles and those two sluts  
Cynna and Salabaccho—I may dine  
in the Prytaneum, as I do now,  
though I have not achieved a thing.<sup>86</sup> But if  
I hate you, Demos, if I'm not prepared  
to fight bravely for you all by myself, 1020  
may I be destroyed—sawn in two, cut up  
into leather straps for horses' halters.

### SAUSAGE SELLER

And if I don't love and value you, Demos,  
may I be diced up and boiled as mincemeat.  
If you don't believe that, may I be grated [770]  
on this very table, chopped up with cheese,  
mashed into a paste, may I be dragged off  
to Kerameikos by my own meat hook  
speared through my balls.<sup>87</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

Demos, how could there be  
a citizen who loves you more than me? 1030  
First of all, when I was on the Council,  
in the treasury I produced for you  
massive sums of money—I had some men

---

<sup>85</sup>The lead weights (called "dolphins" because of their shape) were raised high and then dropped on the deck of the enemy ship in order to shatter its timbers.

<sup>86</sup>Lysicles was a political figure in Athens who had died in the war. He lived with Pericles's mistress after Pericles died of the plague. Cynna and Salabaccha were well-known prostitutes. I have added the word "sluts" to make that more explicit.

<sup>87</sup>Kerameikos is a region of Athens. Sommerstein notes that it was the area with the largest cemeteries, so that the Sausage Seller may be saying he'll be hauled off for burial.

## KNIGHTS

tortured, others throttled, and from others  
I asked for a financial split—and I  
never worried about private citizens,  
if I could make you happy.

### SAUSAGE SELLER

Hey, Demos,  
there's nothing so wonderful about that.  
I'll do that for you, as well. I'll steal bread  
from other men and serve it up to you. 1040  
This man does not love you, and his feelings [780]  
for you are not friendly—except for one thing:  
he enjoys warming himself at your fire.  
That's the first thing I'll demonstrate to you.  
You who took your swords against the Persians  
at Marathon to save your native land,  
and by winning gave us a chance to shout  
such glorious tributes—you're sitting down there  
on those hard rocks, and this man doesn't care,  
unlike me, for I bring you this cushion, 1050  
which I sewed myself. Now, lift yourself up,  
and sit down gently so you don't strain  
that arse that did so well at Salamis.<sup>88</sup>

*[The Sausage Seller helps Demos get up and sit down again on a cushion he has brought with him.]*

### DEMOS

Who are you? Are you from that fine family  
of Harmodius? I must say you've done  
a truly noble act—you're a real friend  
of the people!<sup>89</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

Such tiny flatteries  
to win him over!

---

<sup>88</sup>In the Battle of Marathon (490 BC) an army of Greek states led by Athenians defeated the Persian force, a highlight of Athenian history. In the Battle of Salamis (480 BC) the Persians were defeated at sea, one of a series of defeats which ended the second Persian invasion. The “arse that did so well” in the battle was the backside of each man on the rowing benches, which, as Merry remarks, had a thin cushion underneath it.

<sup>89</sup>Harmodius and his brother in 514 BC had assassinated a brother of the tyrant Hippias. His name became synonymous with Athenians who loved democracy and would fight for it.

SAUSAGE SELLER

Well, you got him hooked  
with lures much tinier than these!

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'm willing to wager my head and state  
that no man has ever shown up who loved  
Demos more than I do or who was better  
at protecting him. 1060

SAUSAGE SELLER

How could you love him  
when for eight years you have seen him living  
in casks, crannies, and turrets, yet show him  
no pity—instead you keep him locked in  
and steal his honey? When Archeptolemus  
brought peace proposals, you ripped them to shreds  
and drove the embassy bringing terms of peace,  
whipping their backsides, out of town.<sup>90</sup>

PAPHLAGONIAN

I did that  
so Demos might rule over all the Greeks—  
for the oracles declare that one day  
he must sit in judgment in Arcadia  
at five obols a day, if he bides his time.  
At any rate, I will feed and care for him  
and use fair and foul means to see to it  
that he receives three obols every day.<sup>91</sup> 1070 [800]

SAUSAGE SELLER

By god, you're not thinking of how Demos  
could rule Arcadia—no—but of how  
you can rob and take bribes from our allies  
and of how the fog of war will guarantee  
Demos doesn't see the crap you're up to,  
so in his distress, need, and lack of cash 1080

<sup>90</sup>The war broke out in 431 BC, seven years earlier, but the various provocations which initiated war started earlier than that. The mention of cramped living conditions refers to the fact that in the early part of the war, the countryside was left undefended and all the country folk came to take refuge in Athens, so that there was an acute shortage of living space. The Spartans sought terms of peace after the defeat at Pylos. Archeptolemus was probably one of the negotiators.

<sup>91</sup>Arcadia is a large region in the Peloponnese. Hence, the implication is that the Athenian people will one day take over that territory and that jurymen will be paid more.

## KNIGHTS

he'll keep gawping after you. But if he  
ever takes off for the countryside and lives  
in peace there, regaining his fortitude  
by munching wheat cakes and saying hello  
to his pressed olives, he will realize  
how you cheated him of many benefits  
with the salary you paid. Then he'll come back 1090  
from his farmland an angry man, seeking  
a voting pebble to use against you.<sup>92</sup>  
You know all this and keep him in the dark,  
with deceiving dreams about his future.

### PAPHLAGONIAN

Is it not disgraceful that you talk of me [810]  
in this manner, falsely accusing me  
in front of these Athenians and Demos,  
when I have done more good things by far  
for Athens than Themistocles ever did.

### SAUSAGE SELLER [*declaiming the first sentence in tragic style*]

O city of Argos hearken to the things 1100  
of which he speaks!

[*He turns his attention to the Paphlagonian.*]

You dare compare yourself  
with Themistocles? He found our city  
partially full and left it overflowing.  
What's more, while she was enjoying breakfast  
he prepared Piraeus for her to eat  
and served up new varieties of fish  
without getting rid of all the old ones.  
But you keep trying to make Athenians  
small-town citizens by constructing walls  
that close them in and chanting oracles— 1110  
and you compare yourself to Themistocles!  
He is sent in exile from the city,  
while you wipe fingers on fine barley cake.<sup>93</sup>

---

<sup>92</sup>Small stones were used to tally the votes in the assembly. Sommerstein points out that Cleon wanted the war to continue, because once it ended the country people would return to their land and realize how much they had lost thanks to the warmongers like Cleon.

<sup>93</sup>It is not clear what walls Cleon built. Themistocles was responsible for the long walls which joined Athens and the port of Pireus in one defensive unit. Themistocles was condemned to exile from

## KNIGHTS

### PAPHLAGONIA

O Demos, is it not shameful to hear [820]  
things like this about me from this fellow,  
all because I love you?

### DEMOS [*to the Paphlagonian*]

Just shut up, you!  
Stop this foul abuse. For far too long now  
you've been getting away with duping me.

### SAUSAGE SELLER

My dear little Demos, he's the worst of rogues,  
who's carried out all sorts of nasty schemes. 1120  
Whenever you are yawning, he taps into  
the sap of those who audit the accounts  
and slurps it down—he uses both his hands  
to scoop up public money.

### PAPHLAGONIAN

You'll pay for that!  
I'll convict you of stealing city cash—  
thirty thousand drachmas!

### SAUSAGE SELLER

Why use your oar [830]  
just to make a splash? You've been committing  
the most disgraceful things against the people  
here in Athens. And I will clearly show,  
by Demeter, that you received a bribe 1130  
from Mytilene—more than forty minas.<sup>94</sup>  
If not, then may I not remain alive.

### CHORUS

O you who appear the greatest benefactor  
for all men, how I envy your persuasive tongue.  
If you keep on attacking in this way, you'll be  
the greatest of the Greeks, and you, all by yourself,  
will govern in the city, control our allies,

---

Athens for running away when charged with treason. The barley cake is called in the Greek “Achillean,” a reference to its superior quality. The fact that Cleon uses such fine cake as a napkin to wipe his fingers on is a sign of his extravagance in a time of war.

<sup>94</sup>Mytilene, a city in the Athenian alliance, rebelled against Athens. The Athenians reacted savagely. Cleon was particularly vehement in proposing vicious punishments against the city. The bribe (a relatively small amount) may have been to get him to mitigate his proposals.

## KNIGHTS

and, with a trident in your hand, will shake things up,  
and by confusing things make piles and piles of money.<sup>95</sup> [840]

### CHORUS LEADER

Don't let this man slip away, now he's let  
you get a grip on him. With lungs like yours  
you'll have no trouble overpowering him. 1140

### PAPHLAGONIAN

Things have not yet gone that far, my good friends,  
by Poseidon. For what I have achieved  
is marvellous enough to shut the mouths  
of my enemies, each and every one,  
as long as one of those shields from Pylos  
still remains.<sup>96</sup>

### SAUSAGE SELLER

You keep clinging to those shields!  
You've given me something to grab hold of.  
If you loved the people, then you should not  
allow these shields to be hung up on show  
with their straps attached. It's a clever scheme,  
Demos, so that if you wish to punish him,  
you won't be able to. You see how he has  
a mob of young leather workers with him.  
Close to them live men who sell our honey  
and those who deal in cheese. All these men  
have put their heads together in one group.  
So if you were upset and looked as if  
you might play around with broken pottery  
and have them ostracized, then late at night  
they would all run out and take down those shields,  
then seize the entries to our stores of grain.<sup>97</sup> 1150 [850] 1160

### DEMOS

That's terrible. Do they still have their straps?

---

<sup>95</sup>The trident is associated with Poseidon, god of the sea and of earthquakes.

<sup>96</sup>The shields of the Spartans captured at Pylos were set up as trophies and put on display. Green notes that when shields were hung up in this way, their straps were normally removed.

<sup>97</sup>Playing around with broken pottery refers to a children's pastime, but it also evokes the practice of ostracism (from the word *ostraka*, the piece of broken pottery used in the voting), by which an Athenian citizen could be exiled for ten years after a vote in the Assembly.



## KNIGHTS

You scoundrel! You've been cheating me too long!  
And short changing people!

PAPHLAGONIAN

But my dear sir,  
don't be the slave of the last word spoken. [860]  
And don't think you will ever come across  
a better friend than me. I am the one  
who put a stop to the conspirators, 1170  
and without my having knowledge of it,  
no one can start a hostile mutiny.  
I shout out who they are immediately.

SAUSAGE SELLER

You're like the fishermen who hunt for eels.  
In calm waters, they catch nothing at all,  
but if they stir up mud, they get a catch.  
So you, too, gain something profitable  
if you disturb the city. Tell me this—  
from all those treated hides you have for sale  
have you ever given this Demos here, 1180  
who you say you love, soles for his shoes.

DEMOS

No, by Apollo. He never has. [870]

SAUSAGE SELLER

Well then,  
do you now see the kind of man he is?  
I, on the other hand, bought this pair of shoes,  
and I'm giving them to you to wear.

*[The Sausage Seller gives Demos a pair of shoes.]*

DEMOS *[taking the shoes]*

Of all men I know, you are, in my view,  
the finest where the people are concerned,  
the most dedicated to the city—  
and to my toes.

PAPHLAGONIAN

Isn't it terrible  
a pair of shoes could be so important, 1190  
and you can't remember all I've done

## KNIGHTS

on your behalf? I'm the one who stopped  
those who screw other men illegally,  
by taking Gryttus from the voting rolls.<sup>98</sup>

### SAUSAGE SELLER

Surely what is terrible is that you  
inspected arse holes and prevented  
buggers breaking laws when there's no doubt  
you made them stop out of sheer jealousy,  
fearing they might turn into politicians.  
But you can look at Demos, who's so old,  
without a coat, and, even in winter,  
you don't think it's proper to offer him  
a garment with two sleeves. I, by contrast,  
am presenting this to you.

[88o]

1200

*[The Sausage Seller takes off his outer coat or cloak and gives it to Demos. Demos tries it on.]*

### DEMOS

What a fine idea—  
even Themistocles never thought of that!  
And although that business with Piraeus  
was clever enough, in my opinion  
it's not a greater notion than this coat.<sup>99</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

My god, what silly tricks you keep using  
to attack me!

### SAUSAGE SELLER

No, I'm simply borrowing  
your strategies, in the same way a man  
who's been drinking, when he needs a shit,  
might help himself to someone else's slippers.<sup>100</sup>

1210

---

<sup>98</sup>Sommerstein notes that any citizen who was a male prostitute could have his name stricken from the voting rolls. It is not clear who Gryttus refers to.

<sup>99</sup>The business with Piraeus was the decision to fortify Piraeus and build the long walls, so that Athens and its harbour would form a single defensive unit. Themistocles was the moving spirit behind that idea.

<sup>100</sup>Merry explains that at a drinking party the slippers were left in the hall. Someone in a hurry to go to the toilet might take any pair of slippers.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN [*taking off his coat*]

You're not going to outdo me with flattery!  
I'll put this over him. You can shove it,  
you scoundrel!

[890]

[*The Paphlagonian tries to place his coat around Demos, who rejects the offer.*]

DEMOS [*struggling against the Paphlagonian*]

Bah! Damn and blast you to hell!  
It stinks of leather—totally disgusting!

SAUSAGE SELLER

He tried to wrap you in that deliberately,  
so he could suffocate you. That's the scheme  
he worked on you before. You know the time  
the cost of silphium stalks was so cheap?<sup>101</sup>

1220

DEMOS

Yes, I remember that.

SAUSAGE SELLER

Well, this man here  
made sure the cost was low on purpose,  
so people would buy the stuff and eat it,  
and then jury men sitting in the courts  
would kill each other with their farts.

DEMOS

By Poseidon,  
that's just what a man from Shitsville told me.<sup>102</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

At that time did you not all turn reddish brown  
from all the farting.

[900]

DEMOS

By god, that was a scheme  
worthy of some rogue we caught red handed.<sup>103</sup>

---

<sup>101</sup>Silphium was a common herb in the Athenian diet.

<sup>102</sup>The Greek place named in the text is *Kopros* (meaning *dung*), an urban area close to Athens.

<sup>103</sup>The Greek text says “worthy of Pyrrhandrus,” a reference which is unclear. The first part of the name means red or tawny. I have substituted the notion of catching someone “red handed.”

KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN [*aside to the Sausage Seller*]  
You bastard!  
You're pissing me off with all this foolery.

1230

SAUSAGE SELLER  
Well, the goddess told me I could beat you  
in slinging bullshit.

PAPHLAGONIAN  
But you won't prevail.

[*He turns back to Demos.*]

Demos, I say I'll offer you a bowl  
of state money, a salary, to feast on—  
and you don't ever have to do a thing!

SAUSAGE SELLER  
And I'm giving you this small container,  
some ointment, to rub into these bruises  
on your shins.

PAPHLAGONIAN  
But I'll pluck out your grey hairs  
and make you young again.

SAUSAGE SELLER  
Look here, take this—  
a hare's tail to wipe your dear little eyes.

1240

PAPHLAGONIAN [*putting his head in Demos's lap*]  
Blow your nose, Demos, and then use my head  
to wipe snot from your fingers.

[910]

SAUSAGE SELLER [*shoving his head down, too*]  
No, no. Use mine.

PAPHLAGONIAN  
No, mine!

[*He turns to the Sausage Seller.*]

I'll make you captain of a ship—  
that will take all your money. You'll have

## KNIGHTS

an old ship, so you never see an end  
of spending cash and making more repairs.  
I'll make sure you get one with rotten sails.<sup>104</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER [*pretending to be very alarmed*]

The man is on the boil! Stop! That's enough!  
He's boiling over. We have to pull away  
some of the faggots and skim off his threats  
with this ladle.<sup>105</sup>

1250

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll make you pay for this—  
I'll crush you with taxes. I'll make sure your name  
is listed among those with lots of cash.<sup>106</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

I will make no threats. But I have a wish—  
may your saucepan of squid be standing there  
sizzling hot and you about to announce  
your view of the Milesians and so gain  
a talent for yourself if you win out;  
may you be making haste to eat the squid  
and still get to the meeting in good time,  
but before you eat the meal, may a man  
come for you, and you, in your eagerness  
to get that talent, swallow down the squid  
and choke on it.

[930]

1260

[940]

CHORUS LEADER

By Zeus, that's a splendid wish!  
Yes, by Apollo and Demeter, too!

DEMOS

I agree, and it's clear enough this man  
is a fine citizen. It's been ages  
since a man of his sort has come along

---

<sup>104</sup>The military leaders appointed commanders of warships, who had to supply and repair the ships, an expensive matter.

<sup>105</sup>The Sausage Seller is here comparing the Paphlagonian to a boiling pot which needs some of the hot liquid removed. The word ladle is not in the Greek, but the Sausage Seller, as Merry suggests (following Green), could produce one from his equipment.

<sup>106</sup>Merry points out that property taxes were first imposed during the war when the treasury was in dire need of money. The amount paid depended on a person's wealth.

## KNIGHTS

for the vulgar common folk. As for you, 1270  
Paphlagonian, you say you love me,  
but you just make me ready for a fight.  
Now, hand back my signet ring—no longer  
will you be my steward.

PAPHLAGONIAN [*removing a large ring*]  
Take it. But know this—  
if you won't allow me to be your steward,  
another man will show up and get his turn,  
someone more disreputable than me. [950]

DEMOS [*inspecting the ring*]  
This cannot be my ring. It looks as if  
the seal's been changed, unless I'm going blind.

SAUSAGE SELLER  
Let me have a look. What was your seal? 1280

DEMOS  
A fig leaf stuffed with beef fat.

SAUSAGE SELLER  
That's not what's here.

DEMOS  
Not a fig leaf? What is it, then?

SAUSAGE SELLER  
A sea gull  
with its mouth wide open—making a speech  
perched high up on a rock.<sup>107</sup>

DEMOS  
O that's dreadful!

SAUSAGE SELLER  
What's the matter?

DEMOS  
Put that ring away!

---

<sup>107</sup>The sea gull (or cormorant) was synonymous with gluttony.

## KNIGHTS

Out of my sight! It's not my signet ring.  
It must belong to Cleonymus.<sup>108</sup>

*[Demos produces another ring.]*

I'll give you this one. You can be my steward.

PAPHLAGONIAN

Master, don't do that yet, I implore you.  
Not before you've heard my oracles.

[960]

1290

SAUSAGE SELLER

And mine, as well.

PAPHLAGONIAN

If you believe this man,  
you'll be flayed into a leather bottle.

SAUSAGE SELLER

And if you trust him, your prick will be sliced  
and cut down to a twig.

PAPHLAGONIAN

My oracles  
state that you are to govern every land  
with a crown of roses.

SAUSAGE SELLER

And mine predict  
you will wear an embroidered purple robe  
with a crown and, standing in a gold chariot,  
you'll pursue Smicythos and his husband  
in the courts.<sup>109</sup>

CHORUS LEADER *[to Sausage Seller]*

Well then, get the oracles,  
so Demos here can listen to them.

1300 [970]

---

<sup>108</sup>Cleonymus, a favourite target of Aristophanes, was an ally of Cleon's and an Athenian general. He had a reputation as a coward and a glutton.

<sup>109</sup>Smicythos is a man known for his effeminate ways. Sommerstein observes that his husband would be with him in the court since a woman could not represent herself in a lawsuit.

## KNIGHTS

SAUSAGE SELLER

All right.

CHORUS LEADER *[to the Paphlagonian]*

And you get yours, as well.

PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll get them.

SAUSAGE SELLER

By god, we'll do it. Nothing's stopping us.

*[The Paphlagonian goes into the house to fetch his oracles. The Sausage Seller moves over to his stuff and rummages through it to find some papers that he can pretend are oracles.]*

CHORUS

How very sweet will be the light of day  
for those who visit here and those who stay  
if Cleon is destroyed—though I did hear  
some crotchety old geezers speaking near  
the list of law suits by the market gate  
who claimed if he had not become so great  
the city would not have two useful boons  
our pounding pestles and our stirring spoons.<sup>110</sup>

[980]

1310

I'm amazed in music he is such a swine.  
His class mates at school say all the time  
he'd tune his strings in the Dorian way,  
unwilling to find out how he might play  
a different mode. His teacher grew stern  
and sent him away, "This boy will not learn.  
The Dorian style is all he will play,  
and when he does he expects you to pay."<sup>111</sup>

[990]

PAPHLAGONIAN *[coming from the house with a pile of scrolls]*

Here, look at this lot. I haven't brought out  
all of them.

1320

---

<sup>110</sup>These two implements are for breaking things down and mixing them up; hence, they are associated with Cleon's style of politics. Note that this is the only time the name *Cleon* is mentioned in the play.

<sup>111</sup>Merry notes that the Dorian style was more serious than the passionate Phrygian style and the more lyrical Lydian style. Sommerstein observes that in the Greek there is a pun on the word *Dorian* because it sounds like *dora* (*gifts, bribes*), so that this mention of music contains another reference to the Paphlagonian's corrupt practices.



KNIGHTS

SAUSAGE SELLER [*with an even bigger pile of scrolls*]

I can't carry all of mine.

By god, I need to take a shit!

DEMOS

What is this?

PAPHLAGONIAN

Oracles.

DEMOS

All of them?

PAPHLAGONIAN

Are you surprised?

By god, I've got a chest jammed full of them.

[1000]

SAUSAGE SELLER

I've got an attic and two apartments full.

DEMOS

Come on, let's have a look. These oracles—  
who do they come from?

PAPHLAGONIAN

Mine are from Bacis.

DEMOS [*to the Sausage Seller*]

Who do yours come from?

SAUSAGE SELLER

They're from Glanis,  
Bacis's elder brother.

DEMOS [*to the Paphlagonian*]

What are they about?

PAPHLAGONIAN

About Athens, about Pylos, about you,  
about me, about everything.

1330

DEMOS [*to the Sausage Seller*]

And yours?  
What are they about?

## KNIGHTS

### SAUSAGE SELLER

They're about Athens,  
about lentil soup, about the Spartans,  
about fresh mackerel, about flour merchants  
who give false measure in the marketplace,  
about you, about me. That man there—

*[He indicates the Paphlagonian.]*

let him suck his own cock.

[1010]

### DEMOS

Well, come on then,  
read them to me—especially that one  
which I enjoy so much, that I'll become  
an eagle in the clouds.<sup>112</sup>

### PAPHLAGONIAN

Then listen,  
and give me now your complete attention:

1340

*[The Paphlagonian reads from one of the scrolls]*

“Son of Erechtheus, hearken to the intent  
of Apollo's oracles, which he pronounces  
through holy tripods from his inner shrine.  
He has ordered you to keep safe the sacred hound  
with the jagged teeth who barks in your defence  
and on your behalf yowls out alarming noises.  
He will furnish you with payments, and if he fails,  
he will go under, for there are countless jackdaws  
who hate that dog and keep screaming after him.”

1350 [1020]

### DEMOS

By Demeter, I do not understand  
a word he says. What does Erechtheus  
have to do with jackdaws and a dog?

---

<sup>112</sup>This mention of an eagle is a reference to a famous oracle of Bacis which promised eternal greatness to Athens.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN

I am that dog. I howl in your defence.  
Phoebus tells you to protect your dog—me.<sup>113</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

The oracle says nothing of the sort.  
This dog here . . .

*[The Sausage Seller indicates the Paphlagonian.]*

. . . is chewing up your oracles  
the way dogs chew on doorposts. I have here  
the proper prophecy about the dog.

DEMOS

Then state it. But first I'll pick up this stone, 1360  
so the oracle about the dog won't bite.

SAUSAGE SELLER *[pretending to read from his scroll]*

"Son of Erechtheus, beware of Cerberus, 1030  
the dog which kidnaps men.<sup>114</sup> When you are at a meal  
he fawns on you with wagging tail, but he's watching  
to devour your dishes, when you look away,  
your mouth agape. Often in the night he sneaks  
into your kitchen rooms, while you are unaware,  
and, like a dog, licks clean your plates and islands."

DEMOS

By Poseidon, Glanis, that's much better!

PAPHLAGONIAN

Well, listen to this one and then decide: 1370

*[The Paphlagonian reads from another scroll]*

"A woman in sacred Athens will bear a lion,  
who will fight for the people against huge clouds  
of gnats, as if he were protecting his own cubs.  
Look after him. Build wooden walls around him 1040  
and towers of iron."

---

<sup>113</sup>Phoebus is another name for Apollo. Erechtheus was a legendary king of Athens. His descendants or sons are the Athenians.

<sup>114</sup>Cerberus is the dog guarding the entrance to the underworld.

## KNIGHTS

Do you know what that means?

DEMOS

By Apollo, I don't.

PAPHLAGONIAN

The god clearly states  
you should look after me, because I am  
that lion symbol.

DEMOS

How did you become  
the lion Simba without my knowledge?<sup>115</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

He's quite deliberately not explaining  
something in that saying—the only wall  
made out of iron and wood inside which  
Loxias has told you to preserve the man.<sup>116</sup>

1380

DEMOS

Why does the god say these words?

SAUSAGE SELLER

He's telling you  
to tie this man down in those wooden stocks,  
the ones which have five holes.<sup>117</sup>

DEMOS

I think that oracle  
is just about to be fulfilled.

[1050]

PAPHLAGONIAN

Don't believe him!  
The crows are jealous. They keep cawing at me.

*[The Paphlagonian reads from another scroll.]*

---

<sup>115</sup>In the Greek there is a relatively feeble joke on the name *Antileon* (meaning *instead of a lion*). Sommerstein states that Antileon is the name of a tyrant from Chalcis. With the name *Simba* and the word *symbol* I have tried to provide some equally feeble English humour.

<sup>116</sup>Loxias is a common name for Apollo.

<sup>117</sup>The wooden stocks have separate holes for each hand, each foot, and the head.

## KNIGHTS

“Cherish the hawk, and remember in your heart  
he was the one who on your behalf brought back  
those young Spartan ravens all chained together.” 1390

### SAUSAGE SELLER

The Paphlagonian was drunk that day—  
that’s why he took such a dangerous risk.

*[The Sausage Seller pretends to read from one of his scrolls.]*

“O poorly counselled son of Cecrops, why believe  
that was a mighty deed?”<sup>118</sup> For even a woman  
can bear a load if a man places it on her.  
But she won’t fight.”

*[The Sausage Seller points to the Paphlagonian.]*

If he went into battle,  
he’d crap his pants.

### PAPHLAGONIAN

But consider the phrase  
“Pylos before Pylos,” something the god  
has drawn to your attention—there is 1400  
“A Pylos before Pylos.”

### DEMOS

What does he mean  
by that expression “Pylos before Pylos”?<sup>119</sup>

### SAUSAGE SELLER

He’s saying he will pile up piles of bath tubs [1060]  
and take them from the wash house.<sup>120</sup>

### DEMOS

So today  
I won’t be having my bath?

---

<sup>118</sup>Cecrops was another legendary king of Athens. His sons are the Athenians.

<sup>119</sup>There was a well known verse (“There is a Pylos before Pylos, and there is another Pylos besides”) which refers to the fact that there were a number of places in the Peloponnese called Pylos, all claiming to be the original city ruled by Nestor in Homer’s *Iliad*. The Paphlagonian is obviously keen to keep mentioning his great military success in the war.

<sup>120</sup>The Greek joke turns on a similarity between the sound of *Pylos* (the place) and *puelos* (meaning a bath tub).

## KNIGHTS

SAUSAGE SELLER

No, you won't,  
since he's taken away our tubs. Here's one—  
an oracle about the fleet. You should  
give it your very close attention.

DEMOS

I'm listening. You read it. First of all,  
how my sailors are going to get their pay. 1410

SAUSAGE SELLER [*pretending to read from a scroll*]

"Son of Aegeus, beware of the fox-dog,  
in case he tricks you. He's full of deceit,  
runs fast, and is cunning and resourceful."  
Do you know what that means?

DEMOS

Well, the dog fox—  
that's Philostratus.<sup>121</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

That's not what it says. [1070]  
It's about the fast ships which collect cash,  
the ones this fellow keeps requesting.<sup>122</sup>  
Loxias is telling you not to give them.

DEMOS

How does a warship become a fox dog?

SAUSAGE SELLER

How come? Because warships and fox dogs  
both move fast. 1420

DEMOS

Then why does it say fox dog  
instead of just a dog?

SAUSAGE SELLER

It's a comparison.

---

<sup>121</sup>Philostratus was a pimp whose nickname was Dog Fox.

<sup>122</sup>The fast ships collecting cash are the ones sent around to the allies of Athens to collect the money they owe for their alliance.

## KNIGHTS

It's saying fox dogs resemble soldiers,  
who, like them, feed on grapes from vineyards.<sup>123</sup>

DEMOS

All right, then. Where's the pay for these fox cubs?

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll see to that and within three days, too.  
But pay attention to this oracle, [1080]  
where Leto's son tells you to shun the port  
called Crooked Harbour—that place may trick you.<sup>124</sup>

DEMOS

What's Crooked Harbour?

SAUSAGE SELLER [*indicating the Paphlagonian*]

It clearly states here 1430  
that Crooked Harbour is this fellow's hand—  
since he's always saying, "My hand's crooked,  
so put something in it."

PAPHLAGONIAN

He's telling lies!  
The correct reading of that cryptic saying  
is that Phoebus means by "Crooked Harbour"  
the hand of Diopeithes.<sup>125</sup> But look here,  
I have an oracle with wings—about you.  
You will become an eagle and a king  
ruling all the earth.

SAUSAGE SELLER

I have one, as well—  
you will rule the Earth and the Red Sea, too, 1440  
be a presiding judge in Ecbatana  
and lick up decorated cakes.<sup>126</sup>

---

<sup>123</sup>Merry notes that Athenian soldiers who had not been paid foraged for food on the farms.

<sup>124</sup>Leto's son is Apollo. The Greek names the port *Cyllene*, a place in Elis, which leads to the pun on the word *kullos*, meaning *deformed* or *crooked*.

<sup>125</sup>Diopeithes was known for his extreme religious views, but there is no evidence he was corrupt or that he had a deformed hand (a characteristic which would seem to be demanded by the dialogue).

<sup>126</sup>Merry notes that by the name Red Sea Aristophanes is referring to the Indian Ocean and that Ecbatana, the capital of Media, is synonymous with enormous wealth and power.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN

In a dream  
I have seen Athena herself. I saw her [1090]  
pouring health and wealth all over Demos  
with a bucket.

SAUSAGE SELLER

I've seen the goddess, too.  
I saw her come in person, moving out  
from the Acropolis—she had an owl  
perched on her helmet. Then over your head  
she poured ambrosia from a little jug,  
and over his head . . .

*[He points to the Paphlagonian.]*

. . . she dumped pickled garlic. 1450

DEMOS

That's splendid! It's really true that no one  
is cleverer than Glanis. And so now  
I commit myself to you, to guide me  
in my old age and to educate me  
once more from the start.

PAPHLAGONIAN

No, no! Not yet!  
I'm begging you. Just wait a little while, [1100]  
so I can provide some barley for you  
and what you need to live on every day.

DEMOS

I can't stand to hear you talk of barley.  
I've been cheated too many times by you 1460  
and by Thuphanes.<sup>127</sup>

PAPHLAGONIAN

How about flour cakes?  
I'll provide some, especially for you!

SAUSAGE SELLER

I'll give you

---

<sup>127</sup>Thuphanes was a minor public official and a crony of Cleon's.



## KNIGHTS

well-kneaded scones and nicely roasted meat,  
All you have to do is eat it.

### DEMOS

All right.

Get a move on with what you're going to do.  
Then I'll hand over the keys to the Pnyx  
to whichever one of you is better  
at giving me good service.

### PAPHLAGONIAN

I'll be the first

to run inside.

### SAUSAGE SELLER

No you won't. I will! [1110]

*[The Paphlagonian and the Sausage Seller both rush into the house.]*

### CHORUS

O Demos your rule  
is surely so fine, 1470  
you're like a tyrant  
men fear all the time.  
But you're easy to fool—  
you like flattering cries  
and love to be praised  
and told plenty of lies.  
You listen to speakers  
with mouth open wide  
your mind may be present 1480  
but it's gone for a ride. [1120]

### DEMOS

If you think I'm a dolt,  
then beneath your long hair  
you've got no brain at all.  
I am fully aware  
that I act like a fool—  
I like drinking each day,  
and I raise up a thief  
for political sway,  
with this purpose in mind— 1490  
when he's stuffed himself fat,

## KNIGHTS

then I lift up my hand  
and knock him down flat. [1130]

### CHORUS

What you do then is good,  
and your style, as you say,  
in these things is profound,  
if you use a sly way  
to keep raising these men  
like our victims of state.  
They grow great on the Pnyx, 1500  
so you won't have to wait.  
Then you take one who's fat,  
if you need to eat meat,  
set him up as an offering  
and have something to eat.<sup>128</sup> [1140]

### DEMOS

Look at me—I am smart.  
I deceive all those men  
who think they're so clever  
and can fool me again.  
I'm on watch for them all, 1510  
and my eye always looks  
though I don't seem to see,  
when they're acting like crooks.  
Then I make them throw up  
what they've stolen from folk—  
on the voting urn top  
they all puke when I poke.<sup>129</sup> [1150]

*[The Paphlagonian and the Sausage Seller return from the house. They are each carrying a chest full of food and are getting in each other's way.]*

### PAPHLAGONIAN

Get the devil out of my way!

### SAUSAGE SELLER

Shove off!

---

<sup>128</sup>The victims of state or public victims were slaves or captives or prisoners who were kept to be sacrificed as scapegoats in a ritual designed to protect the state.

<sup>129</sup>The top of the voting urn or ballot box was shaped like a funnel.

## KNIGHTS

PAPHLAGONIAN

Demos, for a long, long time I've been here  
sitting ready, really keen to serve you.

1520

SAUSAGE SELLER

And I've been ready for ages and ages—  
ten, twelve, a thousand—an infinite time.

DEMOS

I've been waiting thirty thousand ages,  
fed up with you both for an eternity.

SAUSAGE SELLER

You know what you should do?

DEMOS

I will if you tell me.

SAUSAGE SELLER

Send me and him out from a starting line,  
so we can race to see who serves you best—  
under the same conditions.

DEMOS

That we must do.

[1160]

Get in line.<sup>130</sup>

*[The Paphlagonian and the Sausage Seller assume the positions of sprinters about to race off.]*

PAPHLAGONIAN AND SAUSAGE SELLER

Ready!

DEMOS

Then off you go!

*[The Paphlagonian and the Sausage Seller race off to their separate chests and piles of stuff.]*

---

<sup>130</sup>Merry notes that the stage business here involves a race, with the Paphlagonian and the Sausage Seller having chests of food and various goods in different places (on either side of the stage), and Demos having a central position in between the two. Hence, there is a lot of activity involved in the running to and fro, bumping into each other, dropping things, and so on.

## KNIGHTS

SAUSAGE SELLER

I won't let you win by some secret trick! 1530

DEMOS

By god, today my lovers will make me  
extremely happy or else I'll have to  
keep playing the coy coquette.

PAPHLAGONIAN [*running back to Demos*]

Look at this!

I'm the first here—I'm bringing you a chair!

SAUSAGE SELLER

But not a table—I was the first with that.

PAPHLAGONIAN

Look at this. I've brought you barley cake  
prepared by hand with grain from Pylos.

SAUSAGE SELLER

I've got some scooped out bread crusts. They were made  
by the goddess's ivory hand.

DEMOS

Lady Athena,  
how huge your fingers are!<sup>131</sup> [1170]

PAPLAGONIAN

I have pea soup— 1540  
tasty and a splendid colour. Pallas,  
who fought at Pylos, stirred it herself.

SAUSAGE SELLER

O Demos, the goddess is watching you—  
that's clear enough—and now above your head  
she holds a pot brim full of broth.

DEMOS

Do you think  
we'd still be inhabiting this city

---

<sup>131</sup>The statue of Athena in the Parthenon was 33 feet high. Hence, the hands on the goddess were immense. Scooped out bread crusts were used as spoons for soup. Green notes that the line makes better sense if the bread crust is very large so that the part scooped out with a finger is quite big.

## KNIGHTS

if she was not clearly holding over us  
a pan of broth?

PAPHLAGONIAN

And here's a slice of fish—  
it's a present to you from the goddess  
who strikes panic into every army.

1550

SAUSAGE SELLER

And here is meat cooked in its own juices  
from the daughter of a mighty father—  
along with a slice of tripe and sausage.

DEMOS

She's remembering the robe I gave her.  
That's nice.

[1180]

PAPHLAGONIAN

The goddess of the dreadful plume  
bids you eat this flat cake—our ships' oarsmen  
will row faster with the currants.<sup>132</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

Take this, too.

DEMOS

What do I do with these bits of stomach?

SAUSAGE SELLER

The goddess sends these to you on purpose—  
to fix our ships bellies. That makes it clear  
her eye is on our fleet. Have a drink now,  
two measures of wine and one of water.<sup>133</sup>

1560

DEMOS [*sampling the wine*]

Ah Zeus, how delicious that is—that mix  
of wine and water blends so perfectly.

---

<sup>132</sup>There is a pun in the Greek involving the word for *cake* and the word for *row*. I have tried to provide some equivalent with the pun on *currants/currants*.

<sup>133</sup>The Greeks rarely drank undiluted wine. A solution of two parts wine to three parts water was common.

## KNIGHTS

SAUSAGE SELLER

Athena, thrice born, mixed all three parts.<sup>134</sup>

PAPHLAGONIAN

Here, take this slice of rich flat-cake from me. [1190]

SAUSAGE SELLER

But from me you will get an entire cake.

PAPHLAGONIAN

But you don't have stewed hare to give him. I do!

SAUSAGE SELLER [*to himself*]

Damn and blast it! Where can I get a hare?

Come on, brain, produce some devious trick.<sup>135</sup> 1570

PAPHLAGONIAN [*pulling a hare from his supplies*]

You see this, you miserable devil!

SAUSAGE SELLER [*looking into the wings*]

I don't give a damn. I see men coming—  
ambassadors bringing bags of cash to me.

PAPHLAGONIAN [*putting the hare down and moving toward the wings*]

Where? Where are they?

SAUSAGE SELLER [*grabbing the hare*]

What do you care?

Can't you ever stop bothering foreigners?

My dear little Demos, you see this hare—

I'm bringing it for you.

PAPHLAGONIAN

You bloody cheat!

You've stolen my stuff! That's not fair! [1200]

SAUSAGE SELLER

Yes, I have,

---

<sup>134</sup>Athena was commonly called Tritogeneia. It is not clear what the word means but etymologically it could have something to do with the number three (e.g. thrice born, born third). Hence, the link to the wine-and-water mixture.

<sup>135</sup>Merry explains that hare was considered a delicacy in Athens but that during the war they were very scarce, since the Spartans occupied much of the countryside and there were restrictions on imports (hence the later mention of a risk involved).

## KNIGHTS

by Poseidon, just as you nicked those men  
from Pylos.

DEMOS *[to the Sausage Seller]*

If you don't mind my asking, 1580  
tell me this—how did you get that idea  
to steal the hare?

## SAUSAGE SELLER

The idea is from Athena,  
but the theft is all my own.

PAPHLAGONIAN

I took the risk,  
and, in addition, I prepared the meat.

## DEMOS

Get out of here. The one who brings the food is the only one to get my grateful thanks.

PAPHLAGONIAN [*aside*]

Good god, his shamelessness will conquer mine!

## SAUSAGE SELLER

All right, Demos, why not judge which of us was the best to you and to your stomach?

## DEMOS

How do I decide between the two of you, using facts that will make the audience believe the judgement I pronounce is wise?

SAUSAGE SELLER [*pulling Demos aside and lowering his voice*]

I'll tell you. Don't say a word. Go over there to my basket. Check out what's inside it. Then, do that to the Paphlagonian's. That's all you need to judge correctly.

DEMOS [moving to the Sausage Seller's hamper]

Well then, let's see. What's in here?

## SAUSAGE SELLER

It's empty.

## KNIGHTS

Can't you see that? My dear little father,  
I brought everything to you.

## DEMOS

is on the people's side. This hamper

## SAUSAGE SELLER

Now, stroll over here to the Paphlagonian's. Do you see?

## DEMOS

O my, it's full of so many good things!  
A huge piece of cake he's keeping for himself!  
He cut off a slice and gave that to me—  
only this big!

## SAUSAGE SELLER

That's what he did before.  
He gave you a tiny part of what he took  
and set aside most of it for himself.

DEMOS [*to the Paphlagonian*]

You wretch! Was that how you were cheating me,  
by stealing? That symbol of your office—  
I gave it to you.<sup>136</sup> I showered you with gifts.

PAPHLAGONIAN

I did steal, but for the city's benefit.

## DEMOS

Take that badge off—and quickly, so that I can give it to this man.

## SAUSAGE SELLER

Hand it over fast.  
You worthless rogue, you deserve a whipping.

PAPHLAGONIAN

No. There is a Pythian oracle

<sup>136</sup>The “symbol of your office” (in the Greek a *garland*) would be something like an official wreath on his head.



## KNIGHTS

which reveals the name of the only man  
who destiny says will overthrow me. [1230]

SAUSAGE SELLER

It spoke my name, and it was very clear.

PAPHLAGONIAN

All right. I wish to put you through a test  
with certain evidence, to make quite sure 1620  
you match what the god intended. And so  
I will start by examining who you are.  
As a boy, what schooling did you go through?

SAUSAGE SELLER

I was taught in the pits by being thrashed  
where pigs are singed.

PAPHLAGONIAN

What's that you just said?  
That oracle will give me a heart attack!  
All right. What did you learn from the teacher  
in charge of wrestling?

SAUSAGE SELLER

Well, I learned this—  
when I was stealing, I looked straight ahead  
and told a lie.

PAPHLAGONIAN *[aside to himself]*

"O Phoebus Apollo, 1630  
lord of Lycia, what will you do to me?"<sup>137</sup> [1240]

*[He resumes questioning the Sausage Seller.]*

When you were grown up, what was your trade?

SAUSAGE SELLER

I sold sausages and fucked a bit for cash.

PAPHLAGONIAN *[aside to himself]*

My god, I'm screwed! I'm nothing anymore!  
But I'm still riding on one slender hope.

---

<sup>137</sup>This is a quotation from the *Telephus* of Euripides.

## KNIGHTS

*[He returns to questioning the Sausage Seller.]*

Tell me this—where did you sell sausages,  
in the market or at the city gates?

SAUSAGE SELLER

By the gates, where salted foods are sold.

PAPHLAGONIAN *[in tragic style]*

Alas, The god's oracle has been fulfilled!  
Roll this ill-fated wretch inside the house.

1640

*[He takes of the garland symbolizing his office.]*

Farewell, my garland, you must now leave me.  
With great reluctance I abandon you.  
Some other man will now take you up  
and will possess you—no greater thief,  
but perhaps a man with more good fortune.<sup>138</sup>

[1250]

*[The Paphlagonian tosses the garland away and collapses, lying inert on the ground.  
The Sausage Seller catches the garland and puts it on his own head.]*

SAUSAGE SELLER

O Zeus, god of the Greeks, this victory  
belongs to you.

CHORUS LEADER

Hail, glorious conqueror!  
Remember that you have become a man  
thanks to me. I ask for something trifling—  
to be your Phanos and sign your law suits.<sup>139</sup>

1650

DEMOS *[to Sausage Seller]*

Tell me your name.

SAUSAGE SELLER

Agoracritus—

---

<sup>138</sup>These lines, in a parody of tragic style, echo a lament in Euripides's tragedy *Alcestis*.

<sup>139</sup>The Chorus Leader is asking to work for the Sausage Seller by helping him initiate law suits and prosecutions. Phanos performed this work for Cleon. The speech is sometimes assigned to Demosthenes. There is some justification for that, since he first recruited the Sausage Seller, but his reappearance here is dramatically awkward, because he has been absent for so long and has no other lines.

## KNIGHTS

because I was raised on disagreements  
in the market.

### DEMOS

Well then, I place myself  
in the care of Agoracritus—to him  
I hand over the Paphlagonian here. [1260]

### SAUSAGE SELLER

Demos, I will look after you in style.  
You will agree you could not imagine  
any man more friendly to this city  
full of those who love to yawn and gape.

*[Demos and the Sausage Seller go into the house. Some members of the Chorus haul the Paphlagonian off to one side of the stage by his feet and return without him.]*

### CHORUS

What is more beautiful than to sing 1660  
at the start or finish of our choral song  
of those who drive swift horses—with no jokes  
aimed at Lysistratus and in our hearts  
no deliberate wish to harm Thumantis,  
who has no home and craves food all the time—  
O dear Apollo, with many tears he clings 1270  
to thy quiver there in Delphi, begging  
not to live in such wretched poverty.<sup>140</sup>

### CHORUS LEADER

There is nothing hateful in aiming one's abuse  
at wicked rogues—no, if one reasons well 1670  
it's paying a tribute to worthwhile citizens.  
So if the man about whom we must now proclaim  
many bad things were himself well known to all,  
I would not mention someone who is my friend.  
Now, there is no one who can tell the colour white  
from Orthian melodies who does not know  
Agrignotus. Well, that man has a brother,  
Ariphrades, who in his habits is not like him 1280

---

<sup>140</sup>Lysistratus was apparently a well-known pauper in Athens. Thumantis was, one assumes from this passage, an Athenian very down on his luck. The passage seems to mean that at this moment we wish to celebrate ourselves (as Knights) rather than satirize the less fortunate.

## KNIGHTS

and wants to be that way.<sup>141</sup> He is not only bad—  
if that were all, I wouldn't pay him any mind— 1680  
not only completely nasty, but has invented  
something even worse. He corrupts his own tongue  
with revolting pleasures, licking disgusting juices  
from the cunts of prostitutes, staining his beard,  
stirring up coals in those hot fires, carrying on  
like Polymnestus, and hanging out with Oeonichus.  
Any person who does not despise a man like that  
will never drink from the same cup as I do.<sup>142</sup>

### CHORUS

At night certain thoughts often come to me, [1290]  
and I wonder where Cleonymus gets food 1690  
for that voracious appetite he has. They say  
that when he grazed on rich men's tables  
he'd never leave the tub of food alone.  
And they'd keep begging him in unison,  
"O lord, by your knees, leave—spare our table."<sup>143</sup>

### CHORUS LEADER

They say our warships once all met together [1300]  
to chat to one another, and one of them,  
an older lady, said, "Girls, don't you realize  
what's going on in the city? People are claiming  
some man is requisitioning one hundred of us 1700  
to sail off to Carthage—some worthless citizen  
called sour Hyperbolus."<sup>144</sup> All of them thought this  
totally outrageous and would not endure it.  
One of those ships, a virgin who'd not yet come near  
a crew of men, declared, "May god protect us,  
that man will never become my master! Instead,  
I'll grow old here, if I must, with festering wood  
chewed up by worms." "By the gods, he'll not command

---

<sup>141</sup>Agrignotus was a musician popular in Athens. His brother Aripheades, Sommerstein notes, is a frequent target of Aristophanes.

<sup>142</sup>Polymnestus and Oeonichus are, one assumes, known figures in Athens.

<sup>143</sup>Cleonymus, an Athenian politician, is one of the most frequently attacked targets in Aristophanes's plays, usually for his gluttony or his cowardice.

<sup>144</sup>Hyperbolus, another favourite target of Aristophanes, was an up-and-coming politician in Athens. His commercial business was selling lamps. The most ambitious of the war-mongering Athenians, as mentioned before, had lofty imperial ambitions to extend the Athenian empire to Carthage, in North Africa.

## KNIGHTS

Nauphanta, daughter of Nauson, not if I, too,  
am constructed out of pine and timbers. And so, 1710 [1310]  
if Athenians take up Hyperbolus's scheme,  
then I think we should hoist sail and seek refuge  
at the Theseum or the Furies' sanctuary.  
He won't take charge of us and mock the city.  
If that's what he wants, let him sail off by himself  
and descend to Hades, once he's launched those tubs  
he used when trying to sell those lamps of his."<sup>145</sup>

*[Enter the Sausage Seller from the house. He is wearing a rich new outfit.]*

### SAUSAGE SELLER

We must maintain a holy silence,  
keeping our mouths firmly closed, refraining  
from giving evidence, and closing those courts 1720  
from which the city gets so much delight.  
To salute our new good fortune, people here  
should sing a sacred song of gratitude.

### CHORUS LEADER

O you flaming light for sacred Athens  
protector of the islands, what good news  
do you carry as you move here, for which [1320]  
we will make our streets fill up with the smell  
of smoking sacrifice?

### SAUSAGE SELLER

I have boiled Demos,  
made him young again for you and transformed  
something ugly into something beautiful.<sup>146</sup> 1730

### CHORUS LEADER

And so, you fountain of marvellous schemes,  
where is he now?

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<sup>145</sup>The Theseum, the Temple of Theseus, Merry notes, was a famous sanctuary, where slaves took refuge from cruel masters. The Temple of the Furies was a shrine in Athens. Since these were in the city, Sommerstein observes, the ships could not literally sail there.

<sup>146</sup>Merry notes that this mention of boiling is a reference to the famous story in which Medea, a queen with magical powers, rejuvenates Pelias, an old man, in her cauldron.

## KNIGHTS

SAUSAGE SELLER

He lives in ancient Athens,  
that city crowned with violets.

CHORUS LEADER

How can we see him?  
What style of clothing is he wearing?  
What sort of man has he become?

SAUSAGE SELLER

He has become what he was earlier,  
when he lived alongside Aristides  
and Miltiades. But you yourselves can see—  
for I already hear doors opening  
in the Propylaea.<sup>147</sup> Shout out with joy, 1740  
as ancient Athens now comes into view,  
that wonderful place, so often praised in hymns,  
the place where celebrated Demos dwells.

CHORUS LEADER

Splendid, envied Athens, crowned with violets,  
show us the king of all the land of Greece. [1330]

*[Demos emerges through the doors of the Propylaea. He has been completely rejuvenated and is dressed in traditional clothes.]*

SAUSAGE SELLER

Gaze upon this man, with the cicada  
in his hair, glorious in his ancient robes,  
anointed with myrrh and smelling now,  
not of mussel shells, but offerings of peace.<sup>148</sup>

CHORUS LEADER

Hail king of the Greeks. We rejoice with you. 1750

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<sup>147</sup>Aristides and Miltiades were celebrated Athenian leaders in the days of the Persian Wars. The Propylaea is the entrance to the Acropolis in Athens. Presumably we are to assume that Demos's house has now become that symbol of democratic government. The Acropolis of Aristophanes's time did not exist during the Persian Wars. Sommerstein suggests that at this point a platform is rolled out of the doors of the house with a structure on it symbolizing the Propylaea of ancient Athens.

<sup>148</sup>The cicada brooch worn in the hair was a mark of traditional styles of dress, long out of fashion. Mussel shells were used in the law courts as voting tokens.

## KNIGHTS

What you do is worthy of the city  
and of our trophy raised at Marathon.<sup>149</sup>

DEMOS

Come here, Agoracritus, dearest of men.  
What great things you have done, by boiling me!

SAUSAGE SELLER

I did? My friend, if you do not understand  
the kind of person you were previously  
and what sort of things you did, you would think  
I was a god.

DEMOS

Tell me—what did I do before?  
What was I like?

SAUSAGE SELLER

Well, for a start, when someone  
announced in the assembly, “O Demos,  
I am such an ardent lover of yours,  
I am concerned for you and I alone  
look out for what you need,” at that point—  
after someone used these opening phrases—  
you’d always flap your wings and toss your horns.

1760 [1340]

DEMOS

I did that?

SAUSAGE SELLER

Once he’d completely fooled you  
merely with these words, he’d go away.

DEMOS

What are you saying? They did that to me,  
and I never noticed?

SAUSAGE SELLER

Yes. And then, by god,  
your ears would open like a parasol  
and then close again.

1770

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<sup>149</sup>Marathon was the site of the famous victory against the first Persian expedition in 490 BC.

## KNIGHTS

DEMOS

Was I so stupid  
and such a dotard?

SAUSAGE SELLER

Yes, by Zeus, you were.  
If two orators spoke up, one proposing [1350]  
to build long ships for war and the other  
to spend the same amount to pay off  
certain citizens, the one who spoke of pay  
would always go away victorious  
over the man who spoke of warships.

*[Demos turns his head aside.]*

Why hang your head? Can't you stand firm here?

DEMOS

Well, I'm ashamed of earlier mistakes. 1780

SAUSAGE SELLER

You shouldn't think about them. Those mistakes  
were not your fault—no, they were brought about  
by the men who lied to you. Now, tell me,  
if some impudent advocate cried out,  
“You jury men, there'll be no wheat for you,  
unless you convict someone in this case,” [1360]  
how would you treat the man who made that plea?

DEMOS

I'd string him up above the ground, fling him  
into the Barathron, with Hyperbolus  
hanging round his neck.<sup>150</sup>

SAUSAGE SELLER

Now you're talking 1790  
in a reasonable and proper way.  
All right, let's see, what other policies  
would you undertake? Tell me.

DEMOS

First of all,

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<sup>150</sup>The Barathron was a natural gully into which criminals were thrown.



## KNIGHTS

whenever the long ships return to port,  
I will award the rowers their full pay.

SAUSAGE SELLER

You'll please many a worn and blistered bum.

DEMOS

And then, no soldier whose name is entered  
on the roll will be transferred somewhere else [1370]  
because of special interests. It will stay  
where it was written down originally. 1800

SAUSAGE SELLER

That will sting Cleonymus on his shield band.<sup>151</sup>

DEMOS

And no one will hang around the marketplace  
unless he has a beard.

SAUSAGE SELLER

If that's the case,  
where will Cleisthenes and Strato buy things?<sup>152</sup>

DEMOS

By that I mean those young men at the market  
where perfumes are sold, who sit there and chat,  
saying things like, "That Phaeax is so smart!  
The way he escaped death was so clever!  
How stylish the man is, how logical,  
how good at formulating new expressions, 1810  
clear and pointed, and he's the very best  
at silencing those nasty hecklers."<sup>153</sup> [1380]

SAUSAGE SELLER

Surely you'll give these chatterers the finger?

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<sup>151</sup>Citizens eligible for military service had their names written on a list and were conscripted in order, but it was possible to use one's influence to get the position of the name changed and thus to evade having to fight. Cleonymus, a common target of Aristophanes, had a reputation as a coward.

<sup>152</sup>Cleisthenes is often satirized as a beardless and effeminate man. Strato is linked to him elsewhere in Aristophanes as another immature man without a beard.

<sup>153</sup>Phaeax was a well known orator in Athens.

## KNIGHTS

DEMOS

No, by Zeus. I'll force them all to go hunting  
and stop proposing to vote in decrees.

SAUSAGE SELLER [*beckoning to a slave*]

All right then, given that, accept this stool,  
and this slave who will carry it for you.  
He's got enormous balls, and if you like,  
you can make him your camp stool.

DEMOS

My goodness!  
I am reassuming my old habits!

1820

SAUSAGE SELLER

You will claim that for sure when I give you  
the peace terms for a truce of thirty years.<sup>154</sup>

[*He calls into the house.*]

Terms of Peace, come out here quickly.

[*Enter two scantily clad or perhaps naked young girls whom the Sausage Seller presents to Demos.*]<sup>155</sup>

DEMOS

Holy Zeus, they are lovely. By the gods,  
can I play around with them for thirty years?  
Let me ask you—where did you find them?

[1390]

SAUSAGE SELLER

Didn't you know the Paphlagonian  
was keeping them locked up in the house  
where you wouldn't find them? I'm giving them  
to you so you can take them with you  
when you go back to your country home.

1830

DEMOS

And what about the Paphlagonian  
who did all this. How will you punish him?

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<sup>154</sup>Athens had secured a thirty-year truce with the Spartans in 445 BC.

<sup>155</sup>In Athens the girls would have been played by male actors (perhaps in body stockings featuring relevant anatomical details).

## KNIGHTS

### SAUSAGE SELLER

Nothing excessive. He will carry on  
with my old trade beside the city gates,  
selling sausages all by himself. He'll keep  
making a hash of things, but from now on  
with dog and donkey meat. And when he's drunk,  
he'll swap his swear words with the prostitutes, [1400]  
and drink foul water from the public baths. 1840

### DEMOS

That man richly deserves what you've proposed,  
a slanging match with whores and bath attendants.  
And now, in return, I am inviting you  
to the Prytaneum, to take the seat  
which that piece of filth once occupied.  
Put on this frog-green robe and follow me.  
Someone take that fellow away from here  
where he may ply his trade, so that strangers  
whom he used to hurt so much may see him.

*[Some of the Chorus haul away the Paphlagonian. Demos, the Sausage Seller, the Peace Treaty Girls, and the Chorus move off towards the city.]*